

TVK mirrors AAP’s surge to end decades of two-party rule

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a political deja vu, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) led by South superstar Vijay was on Monday poised to win its debut Assembly polls and form a Government in Tamil Nadu under circumstances resonating closely with the rise of Arvind Kejriwal-led Aam Aadmi Party in Delhi over a decade ago.

In a trail-blazing performance, Vijay and his Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) ended decades-long DMK-AIADMK sway over the state politics, as Kejriwal and his Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) did to the BJP and Congress in Delhi.

AAP had formed a minority Government in Delhi after its maiden election in

December 2013, a year after the party was founded, and then went on to win the 2015 Assembly polls with a brute majority.

In the triangular fight, AAP had won 67 of the 70 Assembly constituencies in Delhi, reducing the BJP to a meagre tally of three seats and the Congress to zero. Kejriwal became the chief minister of Delhi, a post he held till September 2024.

As the counting of votes progressed in Tamil Nadu, the TVK, pitted against the ruling DMK and AIADMK, was leading in more than 100 assembly constituencies out of 234 and was heading to form a Government two years after it came into being.

Kejriwal’s rise was rooted in an intense anti-corruption movement that swept India



Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief and candidate from the Tiruchirappalli East constituency, Vijay, shows an election certificate outside a centre as he leads in vote counting for Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in Chennai on Monday

around 2010, giving birth to AAP as a party founded on the promises of alternative poli-

tics and giving primacy to the cause of aam aadmi (common man). Like Kejriwal,

Vijay too vowed to fight against corruption and dynastic politics, more

specifically traditional politics, and took the deep plunge by announcing to go solo in the Assembly polls.

While claiming a clean break from traditional politics, the two leaders and parties have also comfortably used freebies as their poll strategy.

Vijay has promised ₹2,500 monthly assistance to women, six free LPG cylinders for every household, 8 grams of gold and silk saree for brides from low-income families, ₹4,000 monthly support for unemployed graduates and various other facilities.

Free electricity, water, bus travel for women, pilgrimages for the elderly, health facilities and education were the cornerstones of Kejriwal’s model of governance in Delhi

between 2015 and 2025. The TVK’s success instantly drew comparisons between Vijay and Kejriwal and the two parties that started from scratch and instantly rose to power. The emerging tectonic shift in Dravidian politics bore a close resemblance to the circumstances of the rise of AAP, a decade apart.

Vijay launched the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in 2024 and jumped into Tamil Nadu politics, retiring from his acting career, while Kejriwal had resigned as an Indian Revenue Service (IRS) officer and turned social activist before joining the India Against Corruption (IAC) movement and forming AAP.

Even though separated by time, geography and context, both TVK and AAP have an unmistakable similarity of

cashing in on the public disenchantment with old political parties and leaders.

Kejriwal was able to rally the support of the people with his “common man” persona, while Vijay drew on his huge stardom as well as the promise of change.

Further, both AAP and TVK, drawing strength from the popularity of their leaders, have been quick to grasp political success, without following the gradual, incremental growth spread over years and decades.

In both cases, social media and grassroots mobilisation played a crucial role in amplifying the messages of their leaders and expanding their reach beyond traditional political structures based on leader-worker culture.

CM Rekha Gupta warns officials over water supply failures

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With Delhi entering its harshest summer stretch, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday ordered an aggressive citywide tightening of water supply management. She directed officials to prevent shortages, respond to every complaint without delay and face strict action in case of negligence.

At a high-level review meeting held at the Secretariat, the Chief Minister made it clear that the Government was treating this summer as both a supply emergency and a test of administrative delivery, with all major treatment plants, emergency tanker systems and grievance units placed under intensified monitoring.

“Our effort is not confined to temporary relief. We are working simultaneously on durable measures to end Delhi’s recurring drinking water distress,” the Chief Minister said during the meeting attended by Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma and senior officials of the Delhi Jal Board.



The review comes as rising temperatures begin to sharply increase water consumption across the Capital, particularly in the city’s chronically underserved outer colonies. Officials informed the Chief Minister that all major water treatment plants, including Sonia Vihar, Bhagirathi, Chandrawal, Wazirabad, Haiderpur, Nangloi, Okhla, Bawana and Dwarka, have been instructed to run at peak operational capacity through the summer.

Delhi is also maintaining close coordination with Haryana to monitor ammonia levels in incoming

raw water, a recurring issue that can disrupt purification and reduce treated supply to households. To plug immediate shortages, the Government has expanded its groundwater extraction and tanker distribution network.

The number of working tubewells has been raised from 5,834 to 6,200, while operational water tankers have increased from 1,166 to 1,210. Officials said another 100 tankers have been kept in reserve for emergency deployment.

Fixed water supply points across Delhi have also been scaled up sharply from 8,700

to 13,000, while the number of filling hydrants has been marginally increased from 198 to 202.

The Government has identified several high-stress constituencies where summer shortages are historically severe and where tanker movement will be concentrated. These include Sangam Vihar, Matiala, Chhatarpur, Deoli, Tughlakabad, Palam, Bijwasan and Bawana. Officials said constituency-wise micro planning has now been completed, with colony-specific tanker routes, officer deployment charts and local supply schedules prepared in advance. The complaint response system has also been tightened.

Round-the-clock helplines 1916 and 1800117118 have been placed on active monitoring, and every complaint is now being routed directly to the concerned junior engineer for immediate handling. A central control room, chatbot-enabled reporting system and PPP-based call centres have also been added to improve response time.

Across the city, 28 water emergency centres have been activated with staff,

communication equipment and CCTV-backed supervision to handle local disruptions. In parallel, the Government is pushing infrastructure upgrades intended to improve supply beyond this season.

The Chief Minister directed officials to fast-track commissioning of the second 50 MGD water treatment plant at Dwarka Water Treatment Plant. Preparations are also underway to operationalise a 2 MGD recycling facility at the Bawana Water Treatment Plant. Officials said 520 additional tube-wells have been installed over the last year, and 172 kilometres of ageing water pipelines have been replaced to reduce breakdowns and transmission losses.

Valve regulation, sewer cleaning, underground reservoir maintenance and a city-wide leakage repair drive are also underway. Delhi enters every summer with the same fear: taps running dry before the heat peaks.

This year, the Government is betting that tighter control on pipes, pumps, tankers and complaints can prevent that familiar crisis from spilling onto the streets.

Delhi Secretariat hosts Gujarat, Maharashtra Day cultural show

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday held a cultural programme at the Secretariat to mark Gujarat Day and Maharashtra Day, with Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra using the occasion to underline the contribution of both states to India’s economy, culture and national development.



Addressing the gathering, Mishra said Gujarat and Maharashtra have played a major role in shaping the country’s industrial growth, employment generation and cultural identity, and added that Delhi was organising such State day celebrations to strengthen inter-state cultural understanding.

The event, organised by the Sahitya Kala Parishad under the Department of Art, Culture and Languages, brought together a large audience at the Delhi Secretariat and featured folk performances from both western States. Mishra said Gujarat has emerged as one of India’s strongest engines of

economic and industrial growth and described its development pattern as a model that influenced governance thinking in several parts of the country.

He said Delhi, under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, was also moving toward self-reliance and a developed administrative framework through improved governance, digital systems, welfare delivery and business-friendly reforms.

The minister also referred to earlier cultural outreach efforts undertaken by the Delhi Government, including the Somnath-themed

public event and a special train pilgrimage linked to the temple town, to stress that the administration was investing in faith-based and regional cultural connect programmes.

On Maharashtra, Mishra said the State continues to remain a key pillar of India’s economy and public life, with deep contributions in industry, agriculture, infrastructure and the film sector. He invoked the legacy of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj while describing Maharashtra as a State with both historical pride and contemporary economic strength.

The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
IMPAIRED ASSETS RECOVERY BRANCH
Zonal Office Delhi Plot No.132-134 Sector 44,
Gurgaon: (T) 0124-4715800 Email: e:iaridel@jkbmail.com

E-Auction Notice
(For sale of immovable property/ies under the SARFAESI Act, 2002)
"Appendix, IV-A, Refer Proviso to Rule 8(6)"

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and to the borrowers and guarantors in particular that the below mentioned property mortgaged to secured creditor (Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd), the possession of which has been taken by the Authorized officer of the Secured Creditor (Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd) under Section 13(4) of the SARFAESI Act, will be sold through E-auction on **"AS IS WHERE IS"** **"AS IS WHAT IS"** AND **"WHATEVER THERE IS"** and **"NO COMPLAINT"** basis on below mentioned dates, for recovery of amount as mentioned below due to the secured creditor from concerned borrower(s), mortgagor(s) and guarantors. The Reserve Price is mentioned below and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned respectively.

Name & Address of Borrower/ Guarantors	i) Mr. Ashwani S/o Prakash, Present Address: Village Bindapur, Vishwas Park, Block B Uttam Nagar New Delhi-110059, Permanent Address: Plot no.146, B Nagar Q Extension Uttam Vihar, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi 110059. (Borrower/Mortgagor) ii) Mr. Jagmohan Singh Negi S/o: Sher Singh Negi R/o: House No RZ-146, Q-Extension near DDA Flats, Bindapur, Uttam Vihar, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi-110059. (Guarantor) iii) Mr. Rohit Ahuja S/o: Mahinder Ahuja R/o: 6/10, 2nd floor, Subhash Nagar, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi-110027. (Guarantor)
Details of Security Charged covered under Auction	Equitable Mortgage of property "Upper Ground Floor, Front side, Left Hand Side (3BHK) without its roof rights/terrace rights with car parking space at Ground Floor of built up property, bearing Plot No B-10, area measuring 74.07 sq. yds, out of total area 222 sq yds, out of Khasra No 358, situated in the area of village Bindapur, Delhi and colony known as Vishwas Park, Block B, Uttam Nagar New Delhi 110059.
Reserve price	Rs. 28.00 lakh
EMD Amount	Rs. 2.80 Lakh
Bid Increment	Rs. 0.50 Lakh
Outstanding Dues	Rs.45.20 Lakhs as on 30.04.2026
Name & Number of Contact Person & Branch	Mr. Reyaz Ahmad Mr Mob No- 9906980479 Branch Manager Impaired Assets Recovery Branch Mr. Sheeraz Ahmad Shah Mob No. 9103256676 (For Documents purpose)
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) & Other Remittance's details/ by RTGS to Account Number	JAMMU AND KASHMIR BANK LIMITED BRANCH: Dwarka Delhi IFSC CODE: JAKA0DWARKA Account Name:- RTGS INTERBANK RECEIPTS Account Number:- 0521072000000001.
Date & time of E-auction	19.05.2026 3:00 PM to 4:00 PM

Terms & Conditions of E-Auction are as under:
i. The E-Auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" "AS IS WHAT IS" AND "WHATEVER THERE IS" and "NO COMPLAINT" basis and will be conducted online. The bid document/format containing full details of the property and all the terms and conditions can be had from, and submitted on, the website "http://sarfaesi.auctiontnger.net" (contact person Ram Sharma -9978591888, Contact no. 079-68136880/68136837 Mob.:+91 9265562821/18 email: support@auctiontnger.net).
ii. To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized officer, there are no encumbrances on the properties, except specifically disclosed herein. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of property/ies put on auction and claims/rights/dues affecting the property, prior to submitting their bid. The Authorized Officer/Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues. The bidders shall satisfy themselves as to the description, condition or accuracy of the details regarding the property/ies given hereinabove. The e-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank.
iii. The interested bidders shall submit their offer along with EMD through website https://sarfaesi.auctiontnger.net (the user ID and password can be obtained free of cost by registering name with "http://sarfaesi.auctiontnger.net") through their login ID and Password. The EMD 10% of RESERVE PRICE shall be payable through NEFT/RTGS (EMD remittance details given above) on or before 18.05.2026 at 5.00 PM. Please note that Cheques/Demand Drafts shall not be accepted as EMD amount.
iv. The sale shall be subject to rules/conditions prescribed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.
v. The Authorized Officer is not bound to accept the highest offer, and the Authorized Officer has the absolute right to accept or reject any or all offer(s) or adjourn/postpone/cancel the e-auction without assigning any reason thereof.
vi. The other terms and conditions of the e-Auction are available on the website https://www.auctiontnger.net

Date: 04.05.2026
Place: New Delhi
S/d- Authorised Officer,
Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd.
Registered Office: Corporate Headquarters M.A Road Srinagar-190001, J&K, India
CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048; T:+91(0)194 2481 930-35; F: +91(0)194 248 1928; E: info@jkbmail.com W: www.jkbank.com

The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
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Name & Address of Borrower/ Guarantors	i) M/s Aman Trading company, 8/396/11, National Shoe Market, Hing ki Mandi, Agra, U.P.-282003 Through its proprietor, ii) Mr. Mohammad Waseem s/o Mr. Abdul Majeed Khan R/o 9/40, Dera Saras, Nai ki Mandi, Agra, U.P.-282002 (Borrower/Proprietor)
Details of Security Charged covered under Auction	Equitable Mortgage of Single Storey shop bearing shop no.11 located at Ground Floor of Double Storey shopping Complex named National Shoe Market, together with land underneath measuring 617.00 square feet at Minjumala Corp. No 8/396, Hing ki Mandi, Kotwali Ward, Agra (U.P)
Reserve price	Rs. 25.19 lakh
EMD Amount	Rs. 2.50 Lakh
Bid Increment	Rs. 0.50 Lakh
Outstanding Dues	Rs.86.97 Lakhs as on 30.04.2026
Name & Number of Contact Person & Branch	Mr. Reyaz Ahmad Mr Mob No- 9906980479 Branch Manager Impaired Assets Recovery Branch. Mr. Shashi Kumar Gupta Mob No. 9797822254 (For Documents purpose)
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) & Other Remittance's details/ by RTGS to Account Number	JAMMU AND KASHMIR BANK LIMITED BRANCH: AGRA UP IFSC CODE: JAKA0MOGHUL Account Name:- RTGS INTERBANK RECEIPTS Account Number:- 0273072000000001.
Date & time of E-auction	19.05.2026 3:00 PM to 4:00 PM

Terms & Conditions of E-Auction are as under:
i. The E-Auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" "AS IS WHAT IS" AND "WHATEVER THERE IS" and "NO COMPLAINT" basis and will be conducted online. The bid document/format containing full details of the property and all the terms and conditions can be had from, and submitted on, the website "http://sarfaesi.auctiontnger.net" (contact person Ram Sharma -9978591888, Contact no. 079-68136880/68136837 Mob.:+91 9265562821/18 email: support@auctiontnger.net).
ii. To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized officer, there are no encumbrances on the properties, except specifically disclosed herein. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of property/ies put on auction and claims/rights/dues affecting the property, prior to submitting their bid. The Authorized Officer/Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues. The bidders shall satisfy themselves as to the description, condition or accuracy of the details regarding the property/ies given hereinabove. The e-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank.
iii. The interested bidders shall submit their offer along with EMD through website https://sarfaesi.auctiontnger.net (the user ID and password can be obtained free of cost by registering name with "http://sarfaesi.auctiontnger.net") through their login ID and Password. The EMD 10% of RESERVE PRICE shall be payable through NEFT/RTGS (EMD remittance details given above) on or before 18.05.2026 at 5.00 PM. Please note that Cheques/Demand Drafts shall not be accepted as EMD amount.
iv. The sale shall be subject to rules/conditions prescribed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.
v. The Authorized Officer is not bound to accept the highest offer and the Authorized Officer has the absolute right to accept or reject any or all offer(s) or adjourn/postpone/cancel the e-auction without assigning any reason thereof.
vi. The other terms and conditions of the e-Auction are available on the website https://www.auctiontnger.net

Date: 04.05.2026
Place: New Delhi
S/d- Authorised Officer,
Jammu & Kashmir Bank Ltd.
Registered Office: Corporate Headquarters M.A Road Srinagar-190001, J&K, India
CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048; T:+91(0)194 2481 930-35; F: +91(0)194 248 1928; E: info@jkbmail.com W: www.jkbank.com

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PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client, Mr. Sagor Gautam, is the owner of property bearing No. 481, measuring 30 sq. yds., forming part of Khasra No. 610, situated in Colony Malviya, Village Bounha, Pargana Loni, Tehsil and District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. That my client acquired the aforesaid property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 04.07.2023, Document No. 6873, executed by Mrs. Sushma, wife of Mr. Bijendra Kumar. That my client is presently availing a loan from Ujjivan Small Finance Bank Ltd. against the above-mentioned property and has informed me that the following original document pertaining to the said property is not available with him:
1. Original Sale Deed dated 29.03.2005, executed by Mrs. Dalpo (wife of Late Ram Singh) and Mr. Mukesh (son of Late Ram Singh) in favour of Mr. Ranesh Kumar (son of Late Munshi Ram) and Mrs. Shanti Devi (wife of Mr. Ranesh Kumar), bearing Document No. 2358.
All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.
Kamal Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vashi, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my clients, Pooja Gupta and Ankit Gupta, are in the process of purchasing House no.36, admeasuring 120 sq.mts, Block-H, Sector-Beta-02, Greater Noida UP, from Mr. Anur Baisoya, who acquired the said property by virtue of a Gift Deed dated 11/1/2025, Doc.No. 88, executed by Ranish Baisoya. The said purchase is being undertaken by availing a loan from HDFC Bank Ltd. My clients have informed me that the following document pertaining to the said property is not available with the seller. An online FIR has already been lodged in this regard, vide FIR dated 30/4/2026:
1. Original Lease Deed dated 24/3/1986 executed by GMDA in favor of Ved Kumar Sharma Doc No. 4255/4256
2. Original Will dated 21/7/2003 executed by Ved Kumar Sharma in favor of Sukhveer Singh
All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.
Kamal Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vashi, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

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PUBLIC NOTICE

My father Late Sh. SACHINI KUMAR JAIN S/o Late Sh. Naresh Chand Jain R/o Flat 1411, Tower Felicita, Mahagun Maple, Sector 50, Noida, Uttar Pradesh 201301, booked flat/Unit No. R390BR1106/Flat # 1106 in the project called "Supertech ORB" situated at sector-74 Supertech ORB Noida 201307, after his demise, I requested M/s Supertech ORB Project Pvt. Ltd. to transfer the said flat to on my name and my mother's name, along with Mrs. Davinder Kaur Pahwa W/o Mr. Manish Pahwa, D-399, Tagore Garden Extension, West Delhi, Delhi India 110027, if anybody has any objection, he/she may contact M/s Supertech ORB Project Pvt. Ltd. office at GH-01/A, Sector 74, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201301 within 15 days of the Published notice.
M/s. Sonakshi V Jain D/o Late Sh. SACHINI KUMAR JAIN R/o Flat 1411, Tower Felicita, Mahagun Maple, Sector 50, Noida, Uttar Pradesh 201301.
Mrs. Vandana Jain W/o Late Sh. SACHINI KUMAR JAIN R/o Flat 1411, Tower Felicita, Mahagun Maple, Sector 50, Noida, Uttar Pradesh 201301.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mrs. Simran Kaur has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi. (Bank) to avail a Loan against mortgage of SFS Flat No. 6, First Floor, Category-II, Pragati Apartment, Pocket-II, Madipur, New Delhi-110063 and has represented that she is the absolute sole owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 28.03.2025 (Document No. 2024/6/V/6084) and Release Deed dated 28.03.2025 (Document No. 2025/6/V/1921). If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.
Amit Kumar, Advocate
GNA & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110014.

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Ref/No/JKB/ARB/2026-

Date: 09.04.2026

Subject : Notice for Redemption of the property in terms of right vested with Borrower under Section 13(8) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("SARFAESI Act, 2002")

1. **Mrs Monika W/o Satyinder Singh R/o C-53, Shivaji Park, Punjabi Bagh, West Delhi-110026 (Borrower)**
2. **Mrs Monika W/o Satyinder Singh, C-44, shivaji Park, Ground Floor, Backside, West Punjabi Bagh, Delhi-110026 (Borrower)**
3. **Mrs Monika W/o Satyinder Singh, Pvt No. 7, Bharat Garden Matiala Road, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 (Borrower)**
4. **Mr Satyinder Singh S/o Surjeet Singh Dutta R/o C-53, Shivaji Park Punjabi Bagh, West Delhi-110026 (Co-Borrower)**
5. **Mr Satyinder Singh S/o Surjeet Singh Dutta C-44, Shivaji Park, Ground Floor, Backside, West Punjabi Bagh, Delhi-110026 (Co-Borrower)**
6. **Mr Satyinder Singh S/o Surjeet Singh Dutta, Pvt No. 7, Bharat Garden Matiala Road, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 (Co-Borrower).**
Dear Sir/Madam,
As you are aware that the Authorized officer of the Bank had issued a demand notice on 29.08.2023 under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (hereinafter called the Act), against secured interest mentioned therein, which has been offered as security by you towards your/borrower's loan facility/ies.
Subsequently, the Authorized Officer took possession of the secured assets in the nature of Upper Ground Floor without roof/terrace rights, Pvt. No. 07(2BHK) lift facility with common one hatchback car parking space Ground Floor of built up property bearing no 7.8 & 9 area measuring 55 Sq Yds., out of total area 902 Sq Yds, or of khasra No. 1614, situated in the area of village Matiala and the colony known as Guru Har Kishan Nagar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 with proportionate rights of the land underneath on 20.03.2024 under Section 13(4) of Act.
Whereas you have failed to satisfy your/borrower's liabilities to the Bank even after receipt of notice under Section 13(2) and 13(4) of the Act. Therefore, the Bank in exercise of its rights granted under the Act and Rules made thereunder, intends to initiate process of sale for recovery of the amount due.
You are hereby called upon to discharge in full your liabilities amounting to Rs. 34,10,532 (Rupees Thirty-Four Lakh Ten Thousand Five Hundred Thirty Two Thousand) outstanding as on 31.03.2026, with interest, costs and other charges within 30 days from the date of this notice, failing which the Bank shall proceed to realize the outstanding by sale of the mortgaged property.
May note that your right to redeem the mortgaged property shall be extinguished on the date the Bank issues notice of sale as per Act and Rules made thereunder.

Yours faithfully,
Authorized Officer

The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
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Ref/No/JKB/ARB/2026-

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Subject : Notice for Redemption of the property in terms of right vested with Borrower under Section 13(8) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("SARFAESI Act, 2002")

1. **M/s Saree Paloo, S/O Mr. B-111, Basement and Ground, Sector 65, Noida, Up-201307. (Borrower)**
2. **Mr. Satinder Kapoor S/O Mr. Joginder Pal Kapoor, R/O D-13, Anand Vihar, Delhi-110092. (Partner/Borrower)**
3. **Mr. Harjinder Singh Sandhu S/o Mr. Satnam Singh Sandhu R/o: H No. C-1, Aruna Park, Laxmi Nagar, Vikas Marg, Shakarpur, East Delhi-110092 (Partner/ Borrower / Mortgagor).**
4. **Mr. Sulabh Kapur S/o Satinder Kapur R/o: D-13, Anand Vihar, Delhi-110092 (Guarantor)**
Dear Sir/Madam,
As you are aware that the Authorized officer of the Bank had issued a demand notice on 13.01.2020 under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (hereinafter called the Act), against secured interest mentioned therein, which has been offered as security by you towards your/borrower's loan facility/ies.
Subsequently, the Authorized Officer took possession of the secured assets in the nature of Equitable Mortgage of Property bearing no. B-1717(adijoining property B-17/11) measuring 451 1/2 Sq Yard(377.45 Sq mts), situated at Krishna Nagar, village Ghondli, illaga shahadra, Delhi-110051 standing in the name of Harjinder Singh Sandhu S/o Mr Satnam Singh Sandhu R/o House No C-1, Aruna Park, Laxmi Nagar, Vikas Marg, Shakarpur, East Delhi-110092 on 24.08.2022 under Section 13(4) of Act.
Whereas you have failed to satisfy your/borrower's liabilities to the Bank even after receipt of notice under Section 13(2) and 13(4) of the Act. Therefore, the Bank in exercise of its rights granted under the Act and Rules made thereunder, intends to initiate process of sale for recovery of the amount due.
You are hereby called upon to discharge in full your liabilities amounting to Rs. 11,32,40,790.96 (Rupees Eleven Crore Thirty Two Lakh Forty Thousand Seven Hundred Ninety & paisa Ninety Six Only) outstanding as on 31.03.2026, with interest, costs and other charges within 30 days from the date of this notice, failing which, the Bank shall proceed to realize the outstanding by sale of the mortgaged property.
May note that your right to redeem the mortgaged property shall extinguish on the date the Bank issues notice of sale as per Act and Rules made thereunder.

Yours faithfully,
Authorized Officer

Doctor arrested as Delhi Police busts NEET admission fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Crime Branch has busted an organised racket that targeted NEET aspirants and their families with false promises of guaranteed MBBS admissions, rescuing 18 students, including minors, from a flat in Ghaziabad.

The arrest took place on the eve of the NEET examination and involved four accused, including a doctor who had completed his MBBS in Kyrgyzstan and a Bihar-based pathology lab owner identified as the mastermind.

The arrested accused demanded between ₹20 lakh and ₹30 lakh per student, collected original Class 10 and Class 12 mark sheets, blank

signed cheques, and cash as token payments, and separated students from their guardians on the pretext of providing important exam questions before moving them to an undisclosed location.

DCP Crime Branch Sanjeev Kumar Yadav confirmed that a case vide FIR number 110/2026 dated May 3, 2026, has been registered under Sections 318(4), 61(2), and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at the Crime Branch police station.

All four accused have been taken into police custody remand to unearth the full conspiracy, including the middlemen who drew students into the network.

The operation was triggered by specific information received on May 2 from

Anupam Singh Gahlaut, Commissioner of Police, Surat, about an individual using a particular mobile number engaged in suspicious activities and believed to be in Delhi, claiming to arrange NEET admissions. The input was developed in coordination with Karanraj Vaghela, Additional Commissioner of Police, Crime, Surat, using technical surveillance.

The mobile number was traced to the Mahipalpur Extension area of Delhi. A police team searched around a hundred hotels in the Mahipalpur area.

Four individuals from Gujarat were eventually found at one of the hotels, including the accused Vinod Bhai Bhikha Bhai Patel. The complainant present at the



spot confirmed that he had lured them with false assurances of MBBS admission.

Using technical surveillance and information from the accused, a trap was subsequently laid near Manipal Hospital in Ghaziabad, where three students were safely recovered and a second accused, Santosh Kumar Jaiswal, was arrested.

Further leads took investigators to a flat in Ghaziabad where 15 additional students were found, some of them minors. Two more accused at the flat, Sant Pratap Singh and Dr Akhlaq Alam alias Golden Alam, were arrested.

The students were counselled and allowed to leave in time to appear for the NEET examination on May 3. The four accused have dis-

tinct roles in the operation. Santosh Kumar Jaiswal, 50, a graduate originally from Bihar who runs a pathology lab there and lives in East of Kailash, Delhi, is identified as the mastermind who conceptualised the scheme.

Dr Akhlaq Alam, 25, a resident of Gopalganj, Bihar, who completed his MBBS from Kyrgyzstan and is currently preparing for the National Medical Commission examination to practice in India, prepared fake question papers by compiling content from previous years' questions and material from coaching institutes.

Sant Pratap Singh, 59, a property dealer and builder from Lucknow with properties in Ghaziabad and Pune, arranged logistics and pro-

vided his flat as the base of operations. Vinod Bhai Bhikha Bhai Patel, 52, a broker from Surat, educated up to Class 12, identified and approached three aspirants from Gujarat and their families with false promises.

The police have recovered 149 pages of fake compiled question-answer documents, three blank signed cheques belonging to victims, and other incriminating documents from the accused.

Delhi Police has advised students and parents to remain cautious of fraudulent schemes offering guaranteed admissions through illegal means, warning that such claims lead to financial loss and jeopardise students' futures.

Rekha Gupta hails BJP's historic mandate in West Bengal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Describing the BJP's victory as a "historic mandate," particularly in the West Bengal and Assam Assembly polls, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday said the results are a clear endorsement of public trust and the welfare-driven policies under Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

She extended her congratulations to Prime Minister Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah and BJP national president Nitin Nabin. The chief minister said the Centre's development agenda would now benefit West Bengal as well, adding that the state is poised to move forward on a rapid growth trajectory, much like Delhi. The



Chief Minister celebrated the victory at the Delhi Secretariat with her Cabinet colleagues, where the occasion was marked by a light-hearted exchange of traditional Bengali snacks such as jhal-muri and rosogulla. She expressed confidence that people across the country would continue to back development, stability and good governance in the years ahead.

Calling the verdict more than just a political win, Rekha Gupta said it reflects a broader shift in public sentiment.

According to her, voters have moved beyond "empty slogans, divisive narratives and hollow claims of secularism", choosing instead to prioritise tangible development,

transparency and results-oriented governance. She noted that under Prime Minister Modi's leadership, the vision of 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas' has translated into visible impact across States and communities.

Highlighting key central schemes such as Jan Dhan Yojana, Ujjwala Yojana, Ayushman Bharat, Digital India and Atmanirbhar Bharat, Rekha Gupta said these initiatives have brought meaningful changes to people's lives.

She pointed out that efforts to empower the poor, farmers, women and youth have accelerated the country's development journey, while India's growing stature on the global stage reflects strong and decisive

BJP holds rally after saffron surge in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Celebrations broke out outside the Bharatiya Janata Party's national headquarters in Delhi on Monday after the party's sweeping performance in West Bengal, with senior leaders and hundreds of workers taking out a "Bengal Victory March" to mark what they called a historic political breakthrough.

The rally was led by BJP National General Secretary Tarun Chugh and Delhi BJP chief Virendra Sachdeva on Deendayal Upadhyay Marg, where party workers gathered in large numbers amid music, slogans and celebratory dancing.

Chugh described the Bengal outcome as a landmark win under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership and said the verdict had altered the country's political mood. He said BJP workers in Bengal had fought through repeated political hostility and deserved full credit for the result. The march began from outside the BJP National Office and moved toward the National Office Extension before circling Deendayal Upadhyay Udyan and returning to the party headquarters.



BJP supporters celebrate during vote tabulation on the day of Assembly election results across five states, at BJP headquarters in New Delhi on Monday



BJP supporters light firecrackers during vote tabulation on the day of Assembly election results across five states at BJP headquarters in New Delhi on Monday

Fire emergency surge 73% in April as temperatures rise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Fire-related emergencies in the national Capital surged sharply in April, rising 73 per cent from March, while 32 people have died in fire accidents between January and April this year, according to official data.

According to the Delhi Fire Services' (DFS) 'Call Summary 2026', as many as 2,663 fire-related calls were made in April alone, a steep rise compared to 1,538 in March and 1,096 in February. January recorded 1,396 fire calls, taking the total to 6,693 in the first four months of the year.

Overall emergency calls, including fire incidents, animal rescues and other assistance, also peaked in April at 3,914.

The cumulative number of calls attended by the DFS stood at 12,008 from January to April.

Officials said the spike in April could be linked to rising temperatures and an



increase in garbage and dry waste fires. The data showed that incidents involving garbage and rubbish fires rose from 441 in January to 725 in April, indicating a steady upward trend.

In terms of casualties, March recorded the highest number of deaths due to fire incidents at 15, followed by six each in January and February, and five in April.

In May, at least 10 people have died so far. On May 4, a devastating fire ripped through a residential building in East Delhi's Vivek Vihar, killing nine people from two families, including a toddler. An air-condition-

er blast is suspected to have triggered the blaze. The overall death count across all emergency categories stood at 428 during the period, the data showed.

Despite the rising number of fire-related incidents, prompt response by personnel helped save 837 lives, with April alone accounting for 261 rescues, the highest monthly figure this year, the data showed.

Officials said the Delhi Fire Service also undertook extensive rescue operations involving animals and birds. A total of 1,254 animals and 947 birds were rescued over the four months.

Delhi RWAs appeal for fire safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Residents' welfare associations (RWAs) in Delhi on Monday appealed to households to keep exits and windows completely unobstructed and adopt basic fire-safety practices, citing recent incidents in the city.

In an advisory, BS Vohra, president of the East Delhi RWA joint forum, said safety is built through preparation and appealed that every home must identify, plan, and practice clear escape routes to protect loved ones before a fire turns into tragedy.

"When homes become traps instead of shelters, every spark turns into a tragedy. Delhi's rising fire incidents are not just accidents, but warnings we can no longer afford to ignore," Vohra said in a statement.

Atul Goyal, president, United Residents Joint Action (URJA), said it's a matter of grave concern that neither the Government departments nor the individual residents learn anything from



the past experiences of fire incidents in the buildings.

"Absence of any SOP from Delhi Disaster management plan, building bye laws under Master plan of Delhi, fire safety norms, apartment owners association, access to roof rights in builder floors and individual family security in absence of safety from police, all seem to be responsible under the circumstances," Goyal said.

Maharani Bagh RWA urged residents to "Keep a way to escape" at all times and ensure that doors, corridors

and windows are free of obstructions to enable quick evacuation during emergencies." It also emphasised the need for functional smoke alarms and pre-planned escape routes for all family members.

"In view of recent unfortunate incidents, this is a gentle reminder to prioritise preventive electrical maintenance in your homes. Small proactive steps today can help us avoid serious risks tomorrow," Ayesha Kapur, member of the RWA governing body, said.

Toddler dies after falling into open drain in outer delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A two-year-old girl died after she allegedly slipped into an uncovered drain while playing outside her home in outer north Delhi's Mukundpur area, triggering anger among residents who accused civic authorities of ignoring repeated warnings about the dangerous stretch.

The incident took place on Sunday evening in Ishu Vihar when the child walked out of her house to play in the lane and suddenly disappeared, police said. For hours, her family members and neighbours searched frantically through nearby lanes, rooftops and sur-

rounding houses, hoping she had wandered off. As panic spread and there was still no sign of the child, suspicion turned toward the deep open drain running along the residential stretch.

Police and local residents then began a search operation inside the drain. After repeated attempts, the girl was found trapped in thick sludge accumulated inside the drain channel. She was immediately pulled out and rushed to a nearby Government hospital, but doctors declared her dead on arrival.

The death has sparked outrage in the neighbourhood, with residents alleging that the uncovered drain had remained a constant hazard for years and that several complaints to civic authorities had gone unanswered. Locals said the drain runs openly beside the lane without any protective covering or barrier, making it especially dangerous for children who regularly play outside in the congested settlement. Eyewitnesses said the drain is deeper than it appears from above because much of it is layered with black sludge and stagnant waste, making it difficult to detect where a person may sink.

Several residents gathered near the drain on Monday morning and demanded immediate



Representative image

Traffic cop's quick dash saves crash victim in north Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi Traffic Police inspector and a constable helped save the life of a 40-year-old scooter rider who lay critically injured on a north Delhi road after crashing into a divider late at night, officials said on Monday.

The accident took place on May 2 near the Burari Flyover when Inspector Yashpal Bhati of the Northern Range was returning after duty and spotted the man unconscious on the road with serious head and facial injuries.

Instead of waiting for an ambulance, Bhati and Constable Sahdev immedi-

ately stopped, lifted the injured rider into their vehicle and rushed him to the Trauma Centre at Civil Lines, a move doctors later said proved crucial in keeping the victim alive. Hospital staff said the injured man's condition has now stabilised and he is out of danger.

Officials identified the victim as Vinod Chandra Pujari, a resident of West Vinod Nagar. Police said the scooter rider had rammed into the road divider and collapsed on the stretch before the traffic personnel reached the spot. By the time the officers noticed him, he was lying motionless and bleeding heavily from the head and face. With no time



Representative image

to lose, the two policemen chose not to wait for emergency medical support and shifted him directly to the hospital.

The speed of that decision, officials said, made the difference between life and death.

Doctors at the Trauma Centre later informed police that the victim had suffered severe injuries and required immediate treatment. Medical staff said that had there been further delay in evacuation, the situation

could have turned fatal.

Along with ensuring medical admission, the traffic personnel also began efforts to trace the injured man's family. Officials said his relatives were contacted soon after his identity was established and informed about his condition and location.

By Monday, doctors confirmed that Pujari had responded to treatment and was no longer in immediate danger.

Though Delhi Police personnel are frequently first responders on city roads, such interventions often go unnoticed unless an incident turns fatal or sparks public attention.

In this case, officials said,

the officers' presence on the road at the right moment and their decision to act without procedural delay ensured that a badly injured commuter did not become another late-night accident statistic.

The Burari Flyover and adjoining northern corridors witness regular high-speed movement at night, particularly by two-wheelers, and accidents involving divider collisions are not uncommon on poorly lit or fast-moving stretches. Road safety experts have repeatedly underlined that the first few minutes after a major crash are critical, especially in cases involving head trauma and blood loss.

rounding houses, hoping she had wandered off. As panic spread and there was still no sign of the child, suspicion turned toward the deep open drain running along the residential stretch.

Police and local residents then began a search operation inside the drain. After repeated attempts, the girl was found trapped in thick sludge accumulated inside the drain channel. She was immediately pulled out and rushed to a nearby Government hospital, but doctors declared her dead on arrival.

The death has sparked outrage in the neighbourhood, with residents alleging

action against the department responsible for maintaining the area. Many blamed official negligence rather than mere accident.

They said repeated requests had been made to either cover the drain or build a proper safety wall, but no permanent work was undertaken. Parents in the locality said they have long lived with the fear that a child could slip into the open sewage line at any time, especially during evening hours when many children gather outdoors. Police said the body was recovered after a sustained search with the help of local residents.

Defence Minister Rajnath stresses element of surprise in warfare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj/New Delhi

Given the fast-changing nature of warfare, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday underscored the need for cultivating the element of surprise and sustained focus on research.

He also emphasised the need to adopt a proactive approach and build capabilities that enable the country, should the need arise, to launch an unexpected strike against its adversary. "History bears witness that in warfare, the decisive edge invariably belongs to the

side that possesses the element of surprise. While our defence forces are already working in that direction, we must make further progress with greater proactivity," the defence minister said. Rajnath Singh made these assertions in his address to



defence personnel, industry captains, innovators, start-ups and academia representatives during the inaugural session of the three-day North Tech Symposium, organised by the Indian Army's Northern and Central Commands and Society of Indian Defence Manufacturers, in Prayagraj,

Uttar Pradesh.

Highlighting the explosive rate of technological change being witnessed in modern-day warfare, he said, "In the Russia-Ukraine conflict, the nature of warfare transformed from tanks and missiles to game-changer drones and sensors within a span of

merely three or four years. Furthermore, things which are part of day-to-day life are turning into deadly weapons. The pager attacks in Lebanon and Syria have prompted a reassessment of modern warfare methods. In such a situation, we need to be prepared."

Underlining the importance of ensuring adaptability in the present complex and rapidly evolving environment, the defence minister stressed that the nation that, most swiftly, adapts to the technological revolution holds the decisive edge in the future warfare landscape.

BJP sweeps West Bengal, Vijay shocks TN

"This is a game plan by the EC and the BJP as it (poll panel) is not declaring results or leads in areas where we are leading," she said and alleged irregularities in the counting process at some locations. BJP added on Lotus in border, tribal and industrial regions, while the TMC held ground in parts of Kolkata and select rural strongholds. According to the Election Commission, the BJP won or was ahead in 195 of the 294 seats, well ahead of the magic number of 147, and power in the State was finally within its grasp. The Trinamool Congress tally was 90.

In Assam, where the election was a hot-headed affair too, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma led the BJP to another straight victory with leads in 81 of the 126 seats, leaving the Congress far behind at 19. Congress state unit president Gaurav Gogoi faced his first electoral defeat in Jorhat, which he won in the Lok Sabha 2024.

With a major win in its pocket in Kerala, Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and Wayanad MP thanked the people of the state for their overwhelming support. According to the Election Commission website, the UDF was leading or had won in over 95 constituencies in the 140-member House, which is enough to show the way out to the LDF. In Puducherry, the All India NR Congress had won or was ahead in 11 of the 30 seats. The DMK stood at five and the BJP at four. The TVK made its presence felt with three.

The defeats of the TMC, DMK and Left Front come less than a month after a united Opposition handed a rare Women's Bill legislative setback to the ruling NDA in the Lok Sabha. The Lotus bloom in West Bengal, which sends as many as 42 MPs to Lok Sabha, holds the potential to expand its footprint further in the General Elections 2029, which the BJP is already working on after the majority debacle in 2024.

Simultaneously, regional parties, including TMC, which always questioned Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's leadership, have now themselves suffered electoral reverses, and a fresh alignment will be worked out ahead of the crucial Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, and other assembly polls next year.

PM calls West Bengal win a 'new sunrise'

It was also a matter of pride for the BJP that Anga (modern-day Bihar), Banga (Bengal) and Kalinga (Odisha) – the three pillars of ancient India – have chosen the NDA to help take the country forward again, PM Modi said at the victory event attended by BJP president Nitin Nabin, Union ministers Amit Shah and Rajnath Singh, among others. When the BJP has won in Bengal, there should be talk of 'badlav' (change) not 'badla' (revenge), 'bhavishya' (future) not 'bhay' (fear), he said.

Notably, PM Modi chose symbolism as much as celebration when he arrived at the BJP headquarters in New Delhi on Monday, hours after the party's sweeping victory in West Bengal. Known for using attire to signal political messages, the Prime Minister appeared in a traditional Bengali ensemble, aligning his appearance with the State that had just delivered a landmark mandate. He wore a white kurta, known as a panjabi in Bangla, paired with a Tussar silk dhuti edged with a red border, a classic style associated with Bengali men. While the attire celebrated the Bengali culture, the details were deliberate, too.

PM Modi also tucked the end of his dhuti into his kurta pocket, a nuanced touch that mirrors how the garment is traditionally worn in Bengal. Draped around his neck was a cotton scarf featuring buti motifs, the dotted patterns commonly seen in Bengali textiles, adding another layer of cultural reference. The sartorial choice came as the BJP surged past the majority mark in the 294-member Assembly, heading toward a decisive victory that would end the Trinamool Congress's 15-year rule.

Modi recalled his speech on November 14 last year, when the Bihar election results came in, he told the BJP workers from this very spot that the Ganga flows onward from Bihar all the way to Ganga Sagar (in West Bengal). "The lotus has bloomed from Gangotri to Gangasagar," PM Modi said, pointing out that in "Uttarakhand, UP and now West Bengal, today there is a BJP-NDA Government in all these states settled along the Ganga".

"And today, with victory in West Bengal, from Gangotri (Uttarakhand) to Ganga Sagar (West Bengal), it is nothing but the lotus in full bloom. Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and West Bengal today, in these states surrounding Mother Ganga, there are BJP-NDA Governments," he said. Democracy, not fear, won in this festival of democracy in West Bengal, Modi said.

Modi said it was a special day in many ways as it heralds a bright future for the country. "It is a day of trust in the great democracy of India, trust in the politics of performance, trust in the resolve of stability, trust in the spirit of Ek Bharat, Shrestha Bharat.

"I bow before the people of West Bengal, Assam, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu and Keralaam," he said. He highlighted the nearly 93 per cent voter turnout in West Bengal as historic, and said new voting records were also set in Assam, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala. He added that women's participation was exceptionally high, calling it one of the brightest aspects of Indian democracy.

The Prime Minister also took a dig at the Opposition parties on the occasion, indicating that while women - angry over the defeat of the

quota bill in parliament - had exacted revenge over Banerjee in Bengal, a similar fate awaits all the parties that blocked the bill in parliament last month. "I had said a few days ago that parties opposing reservation for women will have to face the wrath of women. The sisters and daughters of our nation have now punished the Congress, Trinamool, and the DMK," he said.

"In Kerala, the Congress has certainly benefited from the ten years of misrule by the Left, but I am confident that the sisters of Kerala will also teach the party a lesson in the next elections. Similarly, the Samajwadi Party will also have to endure the outrage of the women of Uttar Pradesh... The anti-women Samajwadi Party will never be able to wash away its sins, no matter what it tries," PM Modi said.

There was also a word on the fate of the Left, which for the first time since 1977, finds itself without a state to rule following its defeat in Kerala. This, PM Modi said, is a "major shift in Indian politics".

"This is not merely a political shift. It is a shift in mindset. Today's India seeks opportunity. It seeks development. It seeks trust, progress, and stability. Today's India demands a brand of politics that moves the nation forward," he said, indicating that the country's infatuation with the Leftist ideology is finally over.

The BJP, which has sought to wrest Bengal for long, is now set to succeed, leading in 200-plus seats in the state. The party has also won a third straight term in Assam and another one in Puducherry. Modi also lauded the Election Commission and those involved in conducting the assembly elections for maintaining the dignity of India's democracy. "Our constitutional institutions have won, our democratic processes have won. In West Bengal, 93 per cent turnout has been historic. In Assam, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala, new turnout records have been made," PM Modi said in the address on Monday evening.

"Today, I would like to say a big thank you to the Election Commission, its staff, and those who worked during election, and security workers. The history will always remember the contribution of all of you in maintaining the dignity of India's democracy," he added.

PM Modi thanked the voters in five assemblies- Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Assam, Kerala and Puducherry.

Rangasamy secures second term

Rangasamy is a veteran political leader in Puducherry and has been serving as CM of the UT since May 2021.

He has held the CM post for multiple previous terms, first from 2001 to 2008, and again from 2011 to 2016. In 2011, he founded the All India NR Congress after breaking away from the Indian National Congress.

The NDA benefited from a perceived edge in governance delivery, welfare schemes and stability, while the Opposition campaign focused on anti-incumbency and alliances with national players. The BJP, which contested 10 seats, has won two seats and was leading on three. Smaller allies like AIADMK and Latchiya Jananayaga Katchi (LJK), which contested 2 seats each, are leading on one seat each.

The Congress-led SPA underperformed, hampered by internal conflicts and friction over seat sharing. The DMK's presence provided some advantage, but the alliance struggled to counter the incumbency advantage of the Rangasamy Government. Also, TVK's entry reportedly split votes in several constituencies, potentially hurting the SPA more in key urban pockets while carving out its own niche.

LJK founder Jose Charles Martin was elected from Kamaraj Nagar constituency in Puducherry. He defeated his immediate Congress rival P K Devadoss. LJK is an alliance partner of the AINRC-led NDA here. According to Election Commission data, Martin polled 16,592 votes and Devadoss got 10,205 votes.

BJP storms across West Bengal

Voters in both rural and urban Bengal signalled a desire for change. Exit polls and early trends showed the BJP consolidating not just its 2021 base of 77 seats but expanding dramatically into TMC strongholds. The silent wave, described by BJP leaders, captured hidden discontent that pollsters and political analysts often miss.

High female turnout, especially in border districts in Cooch Behar, Malda, and Jalpaiguri, delivered a BJP lead across those seats. Women voters, traditionally a TMC pillar via schemes like Kanyashree and Lakshmi Bhandar, swung heavily against the incumbent. BJP framed these cases not as isolated events but as a pattern of TMC impunity, a narrative that resonated emotionally and electorally.

Women's Safety was the emotional trigger as horrific incidents of Sandeshkhali and RG Kar shook West Bengal. The two high-profile incidents became the BJP's most potent campaign weapons.

BJP fielded Rekha Patra, a victim of Sandeshkhali from Hingalgaon seat, and RG Kar, the victim's mother, Ratna Debnath from Panihati seat. Both won their seats, turning personal tragedies into political referenda on TMC's handling of women's safety.

Further, remnants of the Left front and the Congress voters, disillusioned after years of irrelevance, shifted to the BJP rather than TMC, as the party positioned itself as the only credible alternative in a bipolar contest.

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BJP blended a development pitch with promises of central schemes such as PM Awas Yojana, Ayushman Bharat, unhindered by syndicate cuts, plus an infrastructure focus in North Bengal, already a BJP bastion since 2019.

Leaders like Suwendu Adhikari, who defected from TMC, led aggressive grassroots campaigns, highlighting TMC's internal factionalism and local corruption. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah's rallies emphasised governance over confrontation.

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls conducted by the Election Commission of India, deleting around 9 million names, sparked TMC allegations of bias, but it cleaned the rolls and neutralised some ghost voting concerns without derailing BJP momentum.

BJP's 2021 footprint was largely in North Bengal and parts of Junglemahal. In 2026, it penetrated South Bengal and urban Kolkata seats namely Shyampur, Entally and Behala. This geographic expansion turned a regional challenger into a state-wide force. Record turnout and migrant worker participation further amplified anti-TMC sentiment among voters.

TMC chief Mamata Banerjee's confidence that TMC will cross 226 seats underestimated the depth of public anger. The party leaned heavily on incumbency advantages and welfare schemes but failed to address corruption perceptions or project a fresh face. Internal rifts, defections to the BJP and an over-reliance on muscle power in some areas backfired amid heavy central forces deployment.

BJP's victory marks the first time since 2011 that a non-TMC Government will rule West Bengal. BJP's win has underscored how sustained anti-incumbency, coupled with emotive issues like women's safety and a disciplined opposition strategy, can dismantle even the strongest regional satrap. For TMC, this is a moment of reckoning rebuilding credibility on governance rather than confrontation will be essential if it hopes for a comeback.

West Bengal watchers say, this decisive mandate reflects Bengal's voters demanding accountability, development and change after a decade and a half of one-party dominance. Now the onus is on the BJP to deliver on its promises. For now, the Lotus has bloomed decisively in the land of Maa, Mati, Manush.

Assam: BJP scores a hat-trick

He went on to urge "good" Hindu Congress leaders to join the BJP to secure the state's future and fight the "aggression" of "Bangladeshi Miyas".

He said BJP's victory in West Bengal is a positive news for Assam. "The BJP's victory in West Bengal is positive news for Assam. Now, the India-Bangladesh border will be fenced, which is essential to protect our nation's sovereignty," he said.

"This is the country's victory rather than the BJP's win," Sarma added, who had campaigned extensively for the Assembly polls there. He accused West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of not allotting land for border fencing.

Agriculture Minister Atul Bora of the AGP bagged the Bokakhat seat by a margin of 60,537 over Hari Prasad Saikia of the Rajior Dal. Cabinet Minister and BPF leader Charan Boro retained his Mazbat constituency, defeating the nearest JMM rival by over 55,000 votes. Assam's Minister for Information and Public Relation Pijush Hazarika won the Jagiroad assembly seat by 93,584 votes.

AIUDF supreme and perfume baron Badruddin Ajmal returned to state politics by winning the newly-created Binnankandi constituency, even as his party was reduced to merely two MLAs in its worst-ever Assembly election performance. He won by a margin of 35,380 votes, by defeating Assam Jatiya Parishad's (AJP) Rejaul Karim Chowdhury. Rajior Dal president Akhil Gogoi retained the Sibsagar assembly constituency for the second consecutive term, defeating the BJP's Kushal Dowari by 17,272 votes.

Among the prominent BJP winners are Ministers Ajanta Neog (Golaghat), Ranajo Pegu (Dhemajai), Kaushik Rai (Lakhipur), Prashanta Phukan (Dibrugarh), Krishnendu Paul (Patharkandi) and Bimal Borah (Tingkhong). Assembly Speaker Biswajit Daimary won from Tamulpur constituency by defeating former BTC chief Pramod Boro of the UPPL.

Among the prominent candidates who lost the polls are Leader of the Opposition Debabrata Saikia, Assam Jatiya Parishad president Luriniyoti Saikia, and former Rajya Sabha MP and senior Congress leader Ripun Bora.

BJP bags 4 in State bypolls

The NCP claimed that Sunetra Pawar has set a new national record of the highest victory margin in the assembly elections, surpassing the previous record attributed to BJP's Sunil Kumar Sharma, who had won the Sahibabad segment by 2.14 lakh votes in 2022. In a social media post, Sunetra Pawar thanked the people of Baramati for the overwhelming mandate.

In Nagaland, BJP candidate Daochier I Imchen won the by-election to the Koridang Assembly segment, according to the Election Commission of India (ECI). With the victory, Imchen enters the 14th Nagaland assembly as the youngest legislator at 35. In Tripura's Dharmanagar, BJP candidate Jahar Chakraborti retained the seat with a commanding margin of over 18,000 votes, polling more than 24,000 votes. The bypoll, held after the death of Assembly Speaker Biswa Bandhu Sen, was seen as a test for the ruling

Government. Chief Minister Manik Saha described the outcome as a clear endorsement of his administration's work.

In Karnataka, Congress won both the bypolls. Samarth Mallikarjun won the Davanagere South Assembly seat by a margin of 5,708 votes, the ECI said. In Bagalkot, the other constituency where bypolls were held, Congress candidate Umesh Meti defeated BJP's Veerabhadrayya Charantimath – a former MLA – by a margin of 22,332 votes. The polls were necessitated by the deaths of senior Congress MLAs HY Meti (Bagalkot) and Shamanur Shivashankarappa (Davanagere South).

Vijay outpaces Stalin

The BJP has secured four seats, the Congress two, and others account for eight. Vijay's TVK has secured 34.82 per cent vote-share while DMK 24.13 per cent. Vijay's new outfit fell short of the magic majority mark of 118 seats, leaving it as a strong contender for the next chief minister.

Interestingly, TVK and Vijay differed from "mainstream" political parties and their conventional ways to seek votes. Vijay neither introduced candidates in all the constituencies nor toured all segments or vigorously campaigned in the traditional sense by addressing rallies. He neither met the press nor gave interviews and directly communicated to people via social media. Unusually, he focused on teens, youngsters and children to persuade their parents to vote for TVK. What began as a high-profile political entry quickly turned into a full-blown electoral surge, with TVK gaining ground even in traditional strongholds of the Dravidian majors. This marks one of the rare instances in Tamil Nadu where voters have decisively moved away from the familiar DMK-AIADMK binary. Since 1962, no outsider had truly broken into this rhythm in a lasting way.

Kerala votes for change, backs UDF

As I said before, Keralam has the talent, Keralam has the potential and now Keralam has a UDF Government with a vision to harness both. I look forward to seeing my Keralam family soon," Rahul Gandhi wrote in a post on X.

The LDF's major constituent, CPI(M) got only 26 seats while the CPI won only eight seats. Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan too faced tough fight in his hometown trailing in first six rounds. The CPI(M) faced route in this fortress Kannur and Kozhikode districts and lost to many rebel candidates, tragically felled by UDF. Among incumbent ministers who lost the election were Veena George, MB Rajesh, OR Keli, R Bindhu, J Chinchurani, P Rajeev, KB Ganesh Kumar, VN Vasavan, V Sivankutty, V Abdurahiman, Kadakampally Ramachandran, AK Saseendran and Roshay Augustine.

The CPI(M) described its rout as a "serious setback" for the Left, particularly in Kerala, while warning that the growing footprint of the BJP across States poses a wider challenge to secular politics and the Opposition's INDIA bloc. The party said the results in West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry reflect the "ascendancy of right-wing communal forces led by the BJP," which it termed "a matter of deep concern for all secular, progressive and democratic forces."

Addressing a press conference, CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby said the results underline "two major features": the defeat of the Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Kerala after 10 years in power and the BJP's strengthening position in States like West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry. "The LDF was defeated in Kerala after ten years of continuous rule, during which it had done its best for the welfare of the people despite financial constraints imposed by the BJP-led Union Government," he said, adding that the party would undertake a "comprehensive introspection" to assess the reasons behind the reversal.

The BJP won three seats including those contested by former Union ministers Rajeev Chandrasekhar and V Muraliedharan. The two – in Nemom and Kazhakoottam – are in the Thiruvananthapuram Corporation area, where the BJP has a significant presence. The third seat, Chathannoor, is in Kollam district and was won by BB Gopakumar. UDF has already asked Congress to decide the Chief Minister, leaving to emergence of three names - Leader of Opposition VD Satheesan and senior leader Ramesh Chennithala and AICC general secretary KC Venugopal, who has not contested in Assembly elections. In coming days, High Command will decide the Chief Minister, said Congress leaders.

From silver screen to CM chair: Vijay rewrites...

Addressing youth unemployment, Vijay pledged to create five lakh new Government jobs and offer as many stipendiary internships. Unemployed graduates will be provided a monthly aid of up to ₹4,000.

When Vijay repeatedly asserted that the 2026 Assembly polls was a fight between his party, the TVK and the ruling DMK, many did not buy that argument. Not only on this point, but on several other aspects, TVK and Vijay differed from "mainstream" political parties and their conventional ways to seek votes. Vijay neither introduced candidates in all the constituencies nor toured all segments or vigorously campaigned in the traditional sense by addressing rallies.

But his messages were forwarded again and again in social media and by word of mouth by his fans and followers. He neither met the Press nor gave interviews and directly communicat-

ed to people via social media. Unusually, he focused on teens, youngsters/children to persuade their parents to vote for TVK.

When polling crossed 85 per cent, Vijay, addressed himself as "Vijay Mama" (Vijay uncle) specially thanked "Kutti, Nanba, Nanbees" (little children) for guiding their families. Also, he brilliantly combined elements of Dravidian ideology and Tamil nationalism in formulating his party's ideology. Vijay's family introduced the promotional title "Ilaya Thalapathy" (Young Commander) for his third film itself, Rasigan (1994), which reflected their confidence and understanding of the importance of branding. This moniker would evolve over more than a decade as he matured into the undisputed "Thalapathy."

Now Chandrasekar Joseph Vijay, the 51-year old has successfully graduated as 'Thalaivan' (leader) and Muthalvar (Chief Minister) from being the 'Thalapathy' (commander).

When Vijay's fans, mobilised under the banner of Vijay Makkal Iyakkam (Vijay's forum for the people) won local body polls in 2021 using the actor's photos, it raised eyebrows and set the tone for his eventual political debut. Many of the VMI office-bearers are functionaries of Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK).

When his movie 'Thalaiva (The Leader, 2013)' had the tagline 'Born to Lead,' it gave a first, clear hint of his political ambition, but it was not definitive enough to conclude. However, about two years before Thalaiva, he had called on Anna Hazare at the venue of his fast in Delhi and expressed support, and it set tongues wagging.

As expected, Thalaiva courted controversy, and the movie's release was delayed in Tamil Nadu by two weeks and it was screened only after its tagline had been removed. The AIADMK was in power at that time.

Vijay first appeared on screen as a child artiste in Vetri (1984), a Vijayakanth-starrer directed by his father, S A Chandrasekhar. At 18, he made his debut as a lead actor in 'Naalaiya Theerpu' (1992), a flop. For his second movie, Vijay was cast as Vijayakanth's younger brother in Sendoropandi (1993). The immense popularity of Vijayakanth proved instrumental in the commercial success of the film, which blended action and romance with a narrative of villagers resisting feudal exploitation.

Hindu vote consolidation becomes BJP's...

It counters opposition strategies reliant on minority appeasement and caste fragmentation, amplified by security concerns over illegal immigration, demographic shifts, and cross-border instability.

This dynamic is starkly evident in the BJP-led NDA's decisive victories in the 2025 Bihar Assembly elections (202 seats out of 243) and the ongoing 2026 West Bengal polls, where the BJP has surged past the majority mark, leading in over 208 of 294 seats and has ended TMC's 15-year rule.

In West Bengal, a state sharing a porous 2,200-km border with Bangladesh, Hindu consolidation proved decisive. Record voter turnout, driven largely by Hindu voters, reflected widespread anxiety over infiltration and cultural erosion. Post-Sheikh Hasina's ouster in Bangladesh, reports of Islamist violence against Hindus and minorities under the interim regime heightened fears of spill over. BJP and RSS campaigns framed this as an existential threat, turning historically fragmented Hindu voters across upper castes, OBCs and Matuas into a unified bloc. The party swept border districts like those in North 24 Parganas, Malda and Murshidabad-adjacent areas, where whisper campaigns highlighted Jamaat influence and illegal migrants.

Despite TMC's solid Muslim base (30 per cent of the population) and welfare schemes, anti-incumbency over scandals like Sandeshkhali and RG Kar, combined with Hindu polarisation, delivered the landslide. BJP leaders explicitly credited this consolidation for the surge, dismissing TMC claims of irregularities as desperation.

Bihar, while bordering Nepal rather than Bangladesh, fits the eastern border-state pattern through shared concerns over infiltration routes via West Bengal and demographic pressures. The 2025 NDA sweep (BJP: 89 seats, JD (U): 85) stemmed from alliance consolidation and a 10 per cent vote-share edge over the RJD-led Mahagathabandhan.

Hindu consolidation reinforced this by mobilising non-Yadav Hindu voters, upper castes, EBCs and OBCs, against RJD's traditional Muslim-Yadav (MY) arithmetic. BJP's national Hindutva narrative, amplified by welfare delivery and development promises under the double-engine model, fragmented opposition votes and boosted turnout among Hindu communities wary of perceived minority favouritism. Though alliance arithmetic was primary, the underlying Hindu unity echoed border-state themes of cultural preservation.

Across both states, this consolidation transcends caste by prioritising identity, security, and governance. In border regions, it resonates with lived realities, demographic change threatening local Hindu-majority ethos, allowing BJP to convert 40-45% vote shares into disproportionate seats via first-past-the-post. It neutralises opposition fragmentation while projecting

BJP as the defender of Hindu interests alongside vikas. The twin victories signal the BJP's eastward expansion: from Assam-like border fortresses to Bihar's heartland, proving Hindu consolidation as a reliable multiplier in culturally sensitive zones. As eastern politics realign, this trend underscores how identity, security, and anti-incumbency converge to reshape India's electoral map.

Leaders speak



There was a desperate need for regime change in Bengal for the nation's safety and security.

Infiltration from across the border has become a major concern. With the BJP's victory, peace will return, and the use of Bengal as a corridor for infiltration will be stopped. Saha claimed that for the first time in decades, people in West Bengal were able to exercise their democratic rights without fear or intimidation. Saha said people of that state had been deprived of "real democracy" during the 35-year Left rule and the subsequent 15-year tenure of the TMC, and ultimately, Prime Minister Narendra Modi liberated them.

MANIK SAHA
Tripura Chief Minister



The "resounding victory" of the BJP in West Bengal is a "triumph of nationalism" as he thanked the people of the State for a big mandate to his party. Saini also thanked the people of Bengal as well as Assam, where the BJP retained power and Puducherry, where the NDA made a comeback. BJP's performance in the three states, especially its mega win in West Bengal, ousting Mamata Banerjee-led TMC, triggered celebrations by party workers and leaders across Haryana.

NAYAB SINGH SAINI
Haryana Chief Minister



Kapil Sibal on Monday alleged that the TMC was defeated in West Bengal not by the BJP but by the Election Commission,

central forces and by the disenfranchisement of 2.5 million voters. He claimed that this election was stolen and not won. In a post on X, Sibal said, "West Bengal, TMC was defeated not by the BJP but by Election Commission, Central Forces (CAPF), and by the disenfranchisement of 2.5 million voters." "This election was stolen, not won! We must stand by Mamata," the Independent Rajya Sabha MP said.

KAPIL SIBAL
Rajya Sabha MP

BJP cracks West Bengal with ground-to-top strategy

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi

The 2026 West Bengal Assembly election results represent a seismic shift in Indian electoral politics. Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) historic victory is not accidental but the outcome of a recalibrated, multi-pronged strategy that combined top-down leadership, hyper-local organisation, narrative discipline and exploitation of structural vulnerabilities.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's personal acceptance and aggressive campaigning were pivotal. Modi shed the outsider tag through culturally attuned outreach eating *Jhalmuri* at roadside stalls, boat rides on the Hooghly and defending Bengal's fish-eating heritage against TMC barbs. He held over a dozen rallies, framing the contest as a turning point for development, jobs, women's safety and industrial revival.

In audio messages and final-phase speeches, Modi positioned himself as Bengal's destiny, promising to transform challenges into opportunities. This high-energy blitz, contrasting TMC's defensive posture, resonated amid voter fatigue and helped consolidate

Hindu voters while expanding into urban and southern pockets like Kolkata.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah provided the surgical edge. He camped in Bengal, dividing the state into five organisational zones in Siliguri, Balurghat, Durgapur, Kharagpur, and Hooghly and conducting late-night war-room reviews until 3 am. Shah set an initial target of 170 seats, released chargesheets on alleged TMC scams, promised to recover stolen money with interest, hammered law-and-order, women's safety, and national security (infiltration, border fencing, and CAA implementation) issues. His presence ensured central forces neutralised the alleged TMC muscle power.

Panna Pramukhs and Shakti Kendra Machine played crucial roles. BJP has built a granular apparatus over five years in the form of the Panna Pramukh system in West Bengal; One dedicated worker per 30-60 voters, personally linked to 10-15 families for man-to-man turnout tracking.

To add to Panna Pramukhs were Shakti Kendras (Clusters of 5-7 booths) tasked with adding 15-20 verified voters each



through sustained mobilisation. Booths were categorised in the form of strong, focused, and weak categories and monitored in real time via a Kolkata war room under strategists Sunil Bansal and Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav.

Functionaries were instructed to stay at every one of the 44,376 polling stations until voting ended. This micro-precision, combined with Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls that deleted

around 60 lakh dubious entries, converted anti-incumbency into votes. Record 92.93 per cent turnout favoured BJP in marginal seats.

During campaigns, the BJP stopped criticising TMC's welfare schemes like Lakshmir Bhandar and instead promised higher pay-outs and faster delivery. It focused relentlessly on governance failures corruption, unemployment, post-poll violence, women's safety while maintaining Hindu consolida-

tion without overt religious overdrive in every constituency. Some inroads were even made in Muslim-dominated seats. The party amplified local leaders fluent in Bengali and leveraged RSS-ground cadre for long-term expansion.

TMC's traditional strength rested on three pillars: Mamata Didi's personal brand among rural women, cash-heavy welfare and booth-level cadre intimidation backed by minority consolidation. BJP disman-

tled each as personal attacks were replaced by governance critique, denying Mamata the victimhood narrative. Welfare was matched or outbid, turning TMC's strongest weapon into a comparison game.

Booth muscle was neutralised through central forces, thousands of pre-poll arrests of alleged goons, and superior BJP booth management, creating a visibly freer polling environment. SIR and high turnout exposed the fragility of TMC's inflated voter base.

In essence, the BJP played asymmetrical electoral warfare: superior organisation, technology (real-time polling agents, BPO calls), and central leverage overwhelmed TMC's traditional street power. What began as a 2021 learning curve became a master class in persistent, data-driven expansion.

The win validates BJP's long-game thesis: regional fortresses fall not to sporadic campaigns but to years of cadre-building, precise targeting and timely anti-incumbency waves. For Bengal, the saffron surge ends one era of dominance. The real test for the BJP now begins in delivering development in a culturally distinct but politically charged state.

BJP looted over 100 seats, we will bounce back: Mamata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee on Monday termed the BJP's landslide victory in the State polls "immoral" and alleged that the mandate in more than 100 seats was "looted".

"We will bounce back," Mamata Banerjee said while walking out of the counting centre at her Bhabanipur Assembly constituency.

Mamata Banerjee had reached the counting centre at Sakhawat Memorial Government Girls' High School on Lord Sinha Road in the afternoon amid allegations by the Trinamool Congress that one of its counting agents had been forced out of the venue.



As she came out of the centre, the TMC supremo was greeted by "jai Shree Ram" slogans by BJP

supporters emboldened by their party's sweep in the polls, even more sweetened by the 10,994

lead Suwendu Adhikari gained in Banerjee's Bhabanipur constituency. A visibly distraught Banerjee told reporters that the BJP's victory was "immoral". "They have looted more than 100 seats," she alleged.

The TMC supremo alleged that the "EC's activities with the help of central forces in connivance with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah were illegal".

Alleging that she received flak "for speaking out against the EC's malpractices", the TMC supremo said, "I lodged a complaint with Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Agarwal, but to no avail." "The CCTV was switched off while our agents were not allowed to be inside the counting centre," she claimed.



The remarkable rise of Suwendu Adhikari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Once the poster boy of the Trinamool Congress and a frontline face of Mamata Banerjee's anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram, Suwendu Adhikari's evolution into a formidable BJP rival poised to wrest the State's administrative helm is as dramatic as it is remarkable.

Adhikari not only reprised his victory over Banerjee in Nandigram – achieved five years ago – but eclipsed it in the 2026 polls, delivering a far more emphatic blow.

His triumph extended beyond symbolism when he vanquished the TMC supremo in her own bastion of Bhabanipur by a formidable margin of 15,105 votes, underscoring a political shift that few could have predicted.

That he also retained Nandigram with a comfortable margin of 9,665 votes —

a significant leap from his earlier margin of just 1,956 — now reads almost like a footnote in the larger story of his sweeping success in Bhabanipur.

No wonder, with his twin accomplishments, and coupled with the fact that he engineered the Trinamool's whitewash from his Purba Medinipur backyard ensuring the BJP won all 16 seats in the district, makes him foremost contender for the state's top job, its next chief minister.

The BJP though, while announcing that the party's CM designate would be someone who is born and brought up in Bengal and has undergone schooling in Bengali medium, is yet to officially name Adhikari, or for that matter anyone else, for the post. Adhikari, interestingly meets all the requirements for the top job named by Union Home Minister Amit Shah during his poll campaigns.

People defeated divisive forces: Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Monday hailed NDA's performance in the assembly polls as "historic" and asserted that the opposition INDIA bloc will now "crumble like a pack of cards", blaming Congress leader Rahul Gandhi for the electoral reverses of the DMK and the TMC in the state elections.

Addressing an event organised at the BJP headquarters here to celebrate the party's stunning performance in West Bengal and the NDA's success in Assam and Puducherry, Nabin said that the results of the elections reflect people's continued faith in the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

People have defeated the "divisive forces" and their "anti-Hindu agenda" by giving their mandate to the BJP and its allies in the polls, he added. "People have given historic support to the BJP in the elections," Nabin said.

While the counting of votes was still underway, the trends indicated that the BJP



was poised to record a landslide victory in West Bengal, inflicting a crushing defeat on the ruling TMC, and appeared to be returning to power in Assam and Puducherry with

its coalition partners under the banner of National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

In Tamil Nadu, the DMK appeared to have lost in the elections with the ruling party winning just 44 seats and leading in 16 seats in the 234-member Assembly, and the TVK merging as the single largest party winning 73 seats and leading in 33 seats around 8.30 pm.

The DMK's ally Congress, which won just two seats till the filing of this report, was leading in three other seats. None of the parties including the AIADMK could reach the majority mark. In an apparent reference to the losses that the TMC and the DMK suffered in the state elections, the BJP chief added, "This failure belongs to no one else but Rahul Gandhi, the leader of the INDI Alliance."

"I assure you that after these poll results, the INDI alliance will crumble like a pack of cards," added BJP president.

In Tamil Nadu, the AIADMK won 30 seats and was leading in 17, while its ally, the BJP ended up winning just one seat.

BJP heavyweights register wins in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Riding a strong Statewide performance, the BJP saw several of its heavyweight candidates register significant victories in the West Bengal Assembly polls, though a few prominent faces failed to cross the finish line despite the broader saffron surge.

Former journalist Swapan Dasgupta opened his Assembly account with a win from Rashbehari, overcoming previous electoral setbacks. Veteran leader Tapas Roy also delivered for the BJP, defeating TMC's Shreya Pandey in Manikata.

Among the standout winners was Dilip Ghosh, who returned to the Assembly from Kharagpur Sadar with a margin of over 26,000 votes, reasserting his relevance after a Lok Sabha defeat in 2024.

Leader of Opposition Suwendu Adhikari emerged victorious from Nandigram, defeating his former aide-turned-rival by more than 10,000 votes. However, his high-profile contest against Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in Bhabanipur remained inconclusive, although he was leading with a margin of 554 votes after 16 rounds of counting. Four rounds of counting are still left.

In a politically significant outcome, the mother of the RG Kar hospital rape-murder victim, fielded by the BJP from Panihati, surged ahead with a decisive lead, capitalising on public sentiment, while Left-backed protest face Kalatan Dasgupta finished a distant third.



Former journalist Swapan Dasgupta



Actor-turned-politician Rudranil Ghosh

Actor-turned-politician Rudranil Ghosh secured a win from Shibpur, defeating TMC's Rana Chatterjee, while another celebrity candidate Rupa Ganguly triumphed in Sonarpur Dakshin in a closely fought contest.

In north Bengal, Union minister Nisith Pramanik registered a comfortable victory from Mathabhanga, while Shankar Ghosh retained Siliguri, reinforcing the party's stronghold in the region.

Among other notable winners, Agnimitra Paul retained Asansol South with a massive margin, Subrata Thakur, held on to Gaighata, and former cricketer Ashok Dinda secured victory from Moyna. BJP's Sajal Ghosh wrested Baranagar from the TMC, while Jagannath Chattopadhyay won in Suri.

Party turncoat Arjun Singh led in Noapara, and debutant Tarunjiyoti

Tiwari clinched Rajarhat-Gopalpur, signalling the party's success in fielding fresh faces.

However, the BJP's march was not without setbacks. Rakesh Singh lost to TMC heavyweight Firhad Hakim in Kolkata Port, failing to dent the ruling party's bastion.

Similarly, lawyer-activist Priyanka Tibrewal was defeated in Entally, unable to convert her high-decibel campaign into votes.

In Tollygunge, BJP's Papiya Adhikari was leading by a slender margin against TMC minister Aroop Biswas, indicating a tight finish.

The results, declared for 293 seats with polling in one constituency deferred, reflect a mixed but impactful performance by the BJP's top brass combining high-profile gains with a few notable misses in crucial urban pockets.

Uphill road ahead for Abhishek Banerjee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

The TMC losing its 15-year grip on West Bengal in the face of an unprecedented saffron wave has left the party's de facto second in command, Abhishek Banerjee, staring at a major political crisis, his first real test outside power.

As the BJP surged past the halfway mark and swept the state, the verdict did more than unseat a government. It punctured a political model that the TMC supremo's nephew had sought to build, consolidate and impose on the party. For a leader who had recast himself from a derided "bhaipo" (nephew) to the party's self-styled "senapati", the fall is stark and personal.

If Mamata Banerjee was the face of the TMC's campaign, Abhishek Banerjee was its architect. From candidate selection and organisational resets, to booth management and messaging — all roads led to him.

And this time, those roads led to defeat. The scale of the defeat has faced the TMC with an existential moment.

From leading Bengal's political narrative for over a



decade to being pushed to the margins, the party now faces a churn that goes beyond numbers.

The BJP's sweep across border districts, tribal belts and industrial regions has exposed the TMC's structural vulnerabilities that were papered over in earlier victories. For Abhishek Banerjee, the Diamon Harbour MP, the message is

sharp — the system he built did not just falter, it was overwhelmed.

Within party circles, the shift in his political identity had been unmistakable over the past few years. Once mocked by rivals as "bhaipo" — shorthand for entitlement — he had, through control over the organisation, earned the tag of "senapati" (commander).

But elections are ruthless levellers. The commander has to own the collapse as his imprint on the TMC's Assembly poll blueprint was total and transformative.

Over 70 sitting TMC MLAs were dropped or shifted, and a large pool of new faces was introduced under the guiding principle of performance over patronage, a major break from the party's traditional template of accommodation and localised power centres.

Abhishek Banerjee was betting that a fatigued electorate, weighed down by anti-incumbency and corruption allegations, would reward renewal. For a party that thrived on layered networks and calibrated flexibility, this was not just course correction; it was controlled disruption.

But that did not pay off; it unsettled the very machinery that sustained the party. As the counting day progressed, local equations frayed one constituency after another as disgruntled incumbents turned passive and new candidates, though relatively untainted, lacked the grassroots grip needed for tight contests.

Leaders speak



Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu on Monday termed the BJP's performance in multiple states a

“decisive mandate” reflecting the people's aspirations for progress, stability and development. Khandu joined party workers at the BJP state office and congratulated the central leadership on the party's electoral success, officials said. “Heartfelt congratulations to Hon'ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi Ji, Hon'ble Union Home Minister Amit Shah Ji, and Hon'ble BJP National President Nitin Nabin Ji on the impressive victory in West Bengal, Assam, and Puducherry,” Khandu said in a post on X while extending his greetings to the party's central leadership.

PEMA KHANDU
Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister



Following TVK's strong performance in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi

spoke with party chief Vijay on Monday to congratulate him, emphasising that the mandate reflects the growing voice of the youth, which cannot be ignored. In a post on X, Gandhi said, “I spoke to Thiru Vijay and congratulated him on TVK's spectacular result. This mandate reflects the rising voice of youth, which cannot, and will not, be ignored.” “I reiterate that the Congress party will continue to protect and serve the people of Tamil Nadu and Puducherry,” he said.

RAHUL GANDHI
Congress leader



Ashok Gehlot on Monday alleged that the BJP won the Bengal elections by misusing power. Gehlot added,

“As Rahul Gandhi rightly said, allegations against the TMC Government and its shortcomings allowed the BJP, which has now captured power.” “Lakhs of people could not cast their votes in their own birthplace?” he said.

ASHOK GEHLOT
Former Rajasthan chief minister

Khera's comments hurt Assam, says Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday said that the allegations brought by Congress leader Pawan Khera against his wife before the elections had hurt the sentiments of the people, as it was an attempt to malign an Assamese woman. He maintained that state Congress president Gaurav Gogoi sharing the dais with Khera while the allegations were being levied could be a reason for the former losing his electoral battle.

Addressing a press conference at the state BJP headquarters here, Sarma said, “I have a commitment for Khera...You all wait and watch this film”.

Less than a week before polling, Khera alleged at two press conferences in New Delhi and Guwahati that Sarma's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, possessed multiple passports and foreign companies, which were not disclosed in the CM's election affidavit. The CM and his wife had rejected the allegations, with



Riniki Bhuyan Sharma also filing a police complaint here against Khera. The Congress leader has taken anticipatory bail from the Supreme Court in the matter.

Asked if he will act against Khera now as he had said previously, the CM said, “When Himanta Biswa Sarma says something, I seldom go back on it,” indicating that action will be pursued against the Congress leader.

Taking a sarcastic jibe at Khera,

Sarma said, “I want to thank him. His allegations were against an Assamese woman, which made the people emotional. If he had not done the press conference and Gaurav Gogoi had not sat with him through it, he might not have lost today.”

Gogoi, who was foraying into state politics for the first time, lost to sitting BJP MLA Hitendra Nath Goswami from Jorhat Assembly segment.

Hitendra Nath Goswami made Gaurav Gogoi bite dust in Jorhat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Veteran BJP leader Hitendra Nath Goswami on Monday registered a significant victory, defeating Assam Congress president Gaurav Gogoi by over 23,000 votes in Jorhat.

A seasoned politician with more than three-and-a-half decades in state politics, Goswami's low-key, grass-

roots-focused campaign paid dividends as he secured his sixth term in the assembly.

His win also halted Gogoi's debut attempt to enter the State Assembly, with the Congress leader currently serving as a third-term MP from Jorhat in the Lok Sabha.

The 67-year-old leader relied on his extensive organisational experience and voter outreach to retain the seat for the BJP,



Gaurav accepts moral responsibility for Congress dismal performance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Assam Congress president Gaurav Gogoi on Monday accepted moral responsibility for his party's drubbing in the Assembly elections, but vowed to remain steadfast in the fight for the rights and dignity of the people.

The Congress registered its worst-ever performance in this northeastern state as the party's tally was 19 in the 126-member House. The party had won 26 seats five years ago. Gogoi himself lost from Jorhat to incumbent BJP MLA Hitendra Nath Goswami by over 23,000 votes.

“As the president of Assam Pradesh Congress, I accept the moral responsibility of this defeat. But in this fight of ideals, we will always remain steadfast and continue to fight for the rights and dignity of the people. I am ready to perform whatever responsibility is assigned to me by the top party leadership in the future,” he said in a post in Assamese on Facebook.

The BJP-led NDA retained power for the third successive term with a two-thirds majority. Accepting the people's verdict, Gogoi expressed his gratitude to the voters who



reposed their faith in the Opposition candidates. The Congress was part of a six-party opposition bloc in the election, with the Rajior Dal being the only other member which opened its account. The Rajior Dal secured two seats.

“Heartfelt congratulations and best wishes to all candidates who have won. Hopefully, they will fulfil the hopes and aspirations of the people and work diligently for the sake of the State's progress, peace and prosperity,” Gogoi said.

He said the Congress will analyse the reasons for its defeat and return with a stronger team to work for the people.

People's befitting reply to appeasement, protection to infiltrators: Shah on results

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hailing the BJP's massive win in West Bengal as “historic”, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday said people of the state have sent a strong message to infiltrators and their sympathisers, highlighting that parties engaged in the politics of appeasement will not forget this lesson.

Without naming outgoing Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee who lost in her pocket borough of Bhabanipur, Shah said on X, “Hats off to the people of Bhabanipur. Their mandate has made it clear what fate awaits an anarchic ruler.”

In a series of posts, he remarked that the overwhelming public mandate reflects the people's response to those who create fear, appeasement, and protection to infiltrators.

“Millions of salutations to the people of Bengal...This is the victory of trust in Shri @narendramodi ji over the TMC's 'fear'. For every BJP

BJP Assam victory historic: Saikia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Assam BJP president Dilip Saikia on Monday termed the party's absolute majority on its own in the Assembly polls as “historic”, describing its third successive victory as a “testimony to the fulfilment” of its 2021 election manifesto.

In an interview with PTI, he said the people had given a “mature mandate” after comparing 55 years of “Congress misrule” with the BJP-led NDA government's 10 years of governance. Saikia said the party received overwhelming support from all sections of society.

“Post Independence, this is the first time that an alliance is getting more than 100 seats. The BJP is the only party other than the Congress which got an absolute majority in Assam. This is a historic mandate,” Saikia said. The ruling BJP won 67 seats and was ahead in 15 other constituencies. To form a government, a party or alliance requires 64 seats in the 126-member Assembly.

BJP's ally the Bodoland



Assam BJP president Dilip Saikia during celebrations amid vote tabulation as the party leads in the West Bengal Assembly elections, at the State party headquarters in Guwahati on Monday

People's Front (BPF) bagged seven seats and was leading in another three. Another member of the NDA alliance, Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) won five seats and was leading in five, according to the Election Commission data. “BJP's massive victory in Assam is a testimony to the fulfilment of the 2021 election manifesto. People saw that we tried to fulfil every promise with near perfection,” Saikia said.

“The people understood and realised that what the BJP says, it does that in letter and spirit,” he added.

“All Sanatani and indigenous people accepted us wholeheartedly. People came out in large numbers and voted to secure the future of indigenous people,” Saikia said. This verdict is a “validation of the BJP's agenda” of making Assam developed, peaceful and secured, he said.

largely staying away from media glare during the campaign.

A postgraduate in Chemistry and a trained lawyer, Goswami began his political journey during the Assam Agitation as a student activist before joining the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP).

He was elected thrice consecutively from the Jorhat Assembly constituency as an AGP candidate starting in 1991

and served as a minister in the AGP-led government between 1996 and 2001.

After parting ways with the AGP over differences with its leadership, he joined the BJP in 2014. Goswami won the Jorhat seat in 2016 and retained it in subsequent elections. He also served as Speaker of the Assembly during his initial term as a BJP MLA.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah is being welcomed by party workers at the party headquarters in New Delhi on Monday

worker like me, this is a moment of pride that from the source of Mother Ganga in Gangotri to Gangasagar, today the BJP's saffron flag is proudly waving everywhere,”

He described the BJP's “historic victory” in Bengal as the outcome of the sacrifices, struggles, and “martyrdom” of countless workers.

“It is a triumph of the patience of those families who, even while enduring

violence, never abandoned the saffron flag. In this arduous journey of the BJP from zero to a resounding majority today, I bow to all those workers who offered their lives, endured violence, suffered tortures, and yet never wavered from the path of ideology and to their families. The people of Bengal have paid tribute to all those martyred BJP workers through this resounding majority,” he said.

The BJP on Monday surged past the majority mark in West Bengal, winning 202 seats and leading in four others, to end the 15-year rule of the Trinamool Congress and redraw the state's political map in saffron hues. Shah expressed confidence that the hopes and aspirations demonstrated by Bengal through this trust in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership will be fulfilled.

“The people of Bengal have taught such a lesson to the infiltrators and their sympathisers that the parties indulging in the politics of appeasement will never be able to forget,” he said.

Shah also affirmed that the BJP will work tirelessly to restore the lost glory of Bengal, a sacred land that has been home to great figures such as Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, Swami Vivekananda, Guru Tagore, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, and Dr Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, while striving to realise the dream of ‘Sonar Bangla’.

NCP's Sunetra Pawar sets record with historic victory in Baramati by-election

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The political spotlight has once again turned to Baramati as Sunetra Pawar secured a landmark victory in the recent by-election, setting what is being described as the highest winning margin in the country's electoral history.

Representing the Mahayuti alliance, Pawar delivered a decisive and one-sided mandate, winning by an unprecedented margin of over 2,18,930 votes by the end of the 24th round of counting. The scale of the victory has drawn national attention and placed Baramati back at the center of political discourse.

Congratulating the victory, Narendra Modi said that NDA leader and Maharashtra's Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar has secured an impressive win in the by-polls, highlighting the significance of the mandate.

With this result, Sunetra Pawar has overtaken the previous record held by Sunil Kumar Sharma, who had



won the 2022 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections by a margin of 2,14,835 votes. That record had long been considered difficult to surpass, making Pawar's achievement particularly notable.

The victory also marks a significant moment in Baramati's political history,

as Pawar exceeded the previous local record set by her late husband, Ajit Pawar. In the 2019 Maharashtra Assembly elections, Ajit Pawar had won the seat by 1,65,265 votes against BJP candidate Gopichand Padalkar. That margin was widely seen as

unbeatable—until now. The by-election recorded a voter turnout of 58.17 per cent, but the contest remained largely one-sided from the outset. A major factor was the absence of a strong opposition candidate after Congress nominee Akash More withdrew from the race.

Following this withdrawal, Pawar faced 22 candidates, most of whom were independents or represented smaller parties. These included contenders such as RY Ghutukade of the New Rashtriya Samaj Party and Satish Kadam of the Hindustan Janata Party, along with several independent candidates.

Despite the presence of recognizable figures like Karuna Munde, wife of Dhananjay Munde, and reality TV personality Abhijeet Bhichukale, the opposition failed to gain traction.

Collectively, all 22 opponents managed to secure just 4,837 votes—a figure that underscores the scale of Pawar's dominance and the electorate's consolidated support.

Akhil Gogoi: Lone voice in Oppn camp to win in Assam

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Rajior Dal president Akhil Gogoi is the only prominent opposition leader in Assam who managed to win the Assembly polls and retain his seat, according to the Election Commission on Monday.

Gogoi retained Sibsagar for the second consecutive term, defeating BJP's Kushal Dowari by 17,272 votes. The Opposition leader polled 86,521 votes compared to Dowari's 69,249.

Another NDA ally, AGP's Prodig Hazarika bagged 14,757 votes, EC data showed. Rajior Dal bagged two seats in the 126-member Assembly, the other being Mehboob Muktar, who won from Dhing with a margin of 71,494 votes. Gogoi, who floated Rajior Dal in October 2020, was a prominent face of the anti-Citizenship (Amendment) Act agitation of Assam. Arrested in December 2019 during the protests, he was charged under UAPA and spent 567 days in jail.

Sonowal congratulates Assam CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal on Monday congratulated Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma for leading the BJP-led NDA to a “historic mandate” in the State Assembly elections.

Sonowal, in a statement, said that this historic mandate was a strong endorsement of development-driven governance and people-centric leadership.

“Assam has spoken! In this historic moment, I extend my heartiest congratulations to Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma. Your tireless energy and hard work have played a vital role in ensuring that Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji's message of development reached every corner of the State,” he said.

“Our collective resolve for a safe, secure, and self-reliant Assam will only grow stronger in the days ahead. Our collective resolve to build a developed, secure and self-reliant Assam will grow even stronger in the days ahead,” Sonowal added.



He also expressed his gratitude to the Prime Minister “for his visionary leadership and unwavering commitment to the development of the Northeast.”

“The scale of the victory reflects the deep trust the people place in the PM's leadership and the State Government's consistent focus on inclusive growth, infrastructure development and welfare delivery,” he said.

Assam has witnessed significant progress across sectors, driven by strong coordination between the Centre and the state, and the renewed mandate provides an opportunity to further

accelerate this double-engine momentum, Sonowal added.

“The people of Assam have once again chosen stability, progress and decisive governance. This mandate is not just a victory — it is a responsibility to serve with greater commitment and dedication,” Sonowal said.

The NDA Government will continue to work toward strengthening peace, prosperity and opportunity across the state, with a continued focus on economic growth, youth empowerment, infrastructure expansion and social harmony, he added.

Leaders speak



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday congratulated Vijay on his “spectacular

victory” in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. Naidu wished him success in his efforts to serve the people of Tamil Nadu. “I extend my congratulations to Thiru Vijay on his spectacular victory in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections,” the CM said in a post on X. Likewise, the key NDA ally wished success to the actor-politician in his efforts to contribute meaningfully to the progress and well-being of the people of Tamil Nadu. Tamil Nadu went to the polls on April 23

N CHANDRABABU NAIDU
Andhra Pradesh CM



A former BJP president K Annamalai on Monday hailed the “generational shift” in the state’s political landscape

following the 2026 Assembly election results, congratulating actor-turned-politician Vijay and his party TVK on a “spectacular debut”. “I bow down to the people of TN for your verdict. Happy to see in my land, people have risen in one voice and spoken – no to buying of votes, no to dynastic politics,” Annamalai said. The BJP leader, who has consistently campaigned against the Dravidian majors, noted that the state was ready for a new era.

K ANNAMALAI
Tamil Nadu former BJP president



YSRCP supremo Jagan Mohan Reddy on Monday congratulated Vijay, chief of TVK, on his party emerging as the

single largest party in Tamil Nadu in its very first election. “A special and heartfelt shoutout to my dear brother, Vijay! Emerging as the single largest party in your very first election is impressive. Wishing you immense strength and success as you embark on this new chapter of service,” Reddy said on ‘X’, adding, “God be with you.”

JAGAN MOHAN REDDY
YSRCP Supremo

TVK: Newest unicorn in political startup map

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The remarkable electoral debut of actor-turned-politician Vijay’s TVK, which is the front-runner to form the Government in Tamil Nadu, has put the spotlight on political ‘startups’, very few of which turned ‘unicorns’ instantly.

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) has followed in the footsteps of parties such as the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in moving to form the Government after its very first electoral outing.

While the AAP had formed the Government with the support of the Congress following its debut election of 2013, the AGP had formed a Government in 1985, soon after its formation, with the support

of the successful independent candidates affiliated with the Assam movement. The TDP had swept the Andhra Pradesh Assembly polls in 1983 with a huge majority, winning 201 seats, a year after its formation. However, not many political startups have turned unicorns, while some took time, others failed to leave an imprint.

Just last year, the Jan Suraj bit the dust. There have been other parties also that created a strong buzz but failed to succeed at the hustings, such as actor-turned-politician Kamal Haasan’s Makkal Needhi Maiam, which drew a blank in the 2021 Tamil Nadu Assembly polls.

The TVK from the start created a strong buzz, and with several political ‘startups’ formed by movie stars doing well in the past in the South, there were high expectations from it in



the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls. The TVK has stunned one and all, causing a major political earthquake in Tamil Nadu by beating both DMK and AIADMK, the two main players in the State since decades.

According to the Election Commission of India (ECI) website, the TVK was leading in 107 seats, the ruling DMK in 58 seats and the AIADMK in 51. The majority mark in the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls is 118.

There are several small ‘startup’ parties in Bihar, such as the Plurals party headed by Pushpam Priya Choudhary. Then there are small parties that have limited ambitions and survive in pockets, such as Jitan Ram Manjhi’s Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) and Upendra Kushwaha’s Rashtriya Lok Morcha. In Uttar Pradesh, there are parties like NISHAD

Party, Peace Party, Apna Dal (Sonelal) and Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP).

In India, parties keep getting formed and disappear after a poor showing at the hustings, hardly creating any buzz. But this could not have been said about Prashant Kishor’s Jan Suraj because it created more than a splash, with many predicting that it could emerge as the next Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in the Bihar polls. However, the media euphoria around it proved to be a mirage as the party was decimated at the hustings and failed to open its account in any of the 238 seats it contested.

If one looks at the political landscape of the country, there are six national parties — BJP, Congress, Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPM), National People’s Party (NPP), and AAP.

Kerala loss a setback, BJP’s Bengal win signals rise of communal forces: CPI(M)

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CPI(M) on Monday described the latest round of assembly election results as a “serious setback” for the Left, particularly in Kerala, while warning that the growing footprint of the BJP across states poses a wider challenge to secular politics and the Opposition’s INDIA bloc.

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) said the results in West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry reflect the “ascendancy of right-wing communal forces led by the BJP,” which it termed “a matter of deep concern for all secular, progressive and democratic forces.”

Addressing a press conference, CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby said the results underline “two major features”: the defeat of the Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Kerala after 10 years in power and the BJP’s strengthening position in States like West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry. “The LDF was defeated in



CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby

Kerala after ten years of continuous rule, during which it had done its best for the welfare of the people despite financial constraints imposed by the BJP-led Union Government,” he said, adding that the party would undertake a “comprehensive introspection” to assess the

reasons behind the reversal.

The CPI(M) also pointed to a churn in Tamil Nadu’s political landscape, where actor-politician Vijay’s party has emerged as a major force, dealing a setback to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-led alliance. “A new political force is inching towards power, reducing other parties to a minority. This is a new development whose implications will have to be watched,” Baby said.

Regarding the West Bengal results, he alleged that the BJP’s gains were aided by multiple factors, including “strong anti-incumbency against the corrupt” Trinamool Congress government, alongside “communal polarisation, huge money power and misuse of central agencies, including the Election Commission of India.”

“Even in such a polarised situation, the Left has marginally improved its performance. In over 30 constituencies, our position has improved, though we expected a far better outcome,” he said.



Sabarinathan, son of Vijay’s driver, wins

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

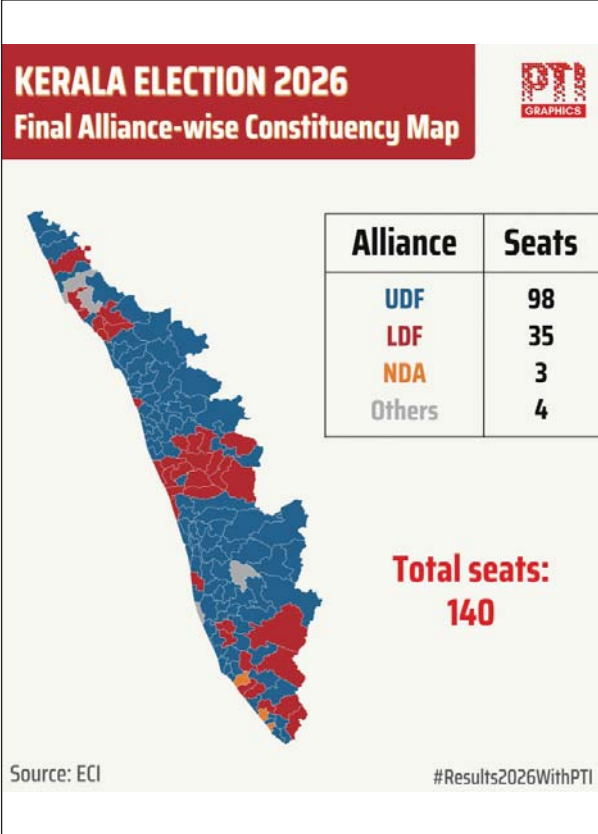
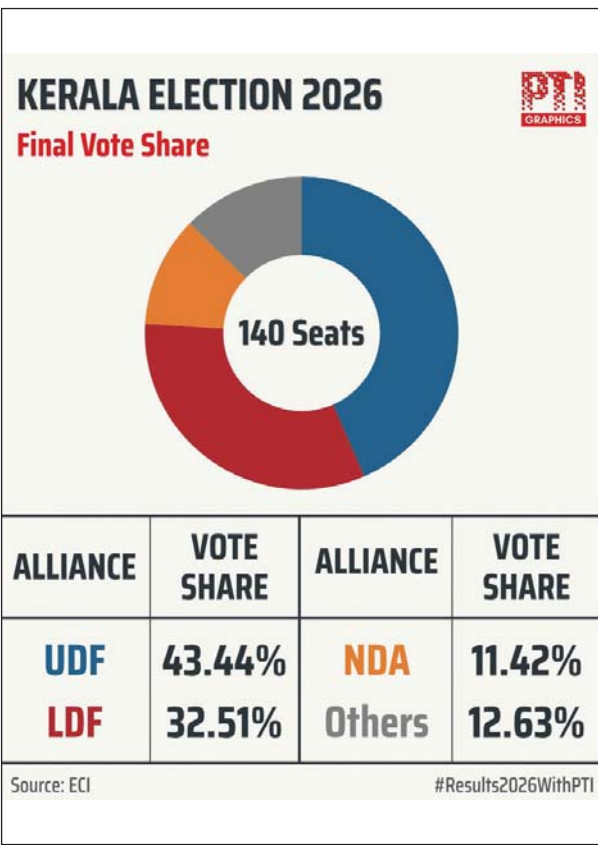
R Sabarinathan, the 30-year-old son of actor-politician Vijay’s long-time driver and personal assistant Rajendran, has won in the Virugambakkam Assembly constituency. Sabarinathan, contesting on a Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) ticket, won by 27,086 votes, according to the latest Election Commission figures.

Speaking to reporters briefly after receiving his certificate, Sabarinathan said, “I am very happy with the win and very grateful to Vijay, he has put an end to DMK.”

Rajendran has been associated with Vijay since the actor’s debut film ‘Naalaiya Theerpu’, serving as his driver and personal aide.

Sabarinathan emerged as one of the most talked-about candidates of the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections after an emotional video of him breaking down on stage went viral, shortly after his name figured among TVK’s list of candidates.

The Virugambakkam constituency, located in Chennai district, has changed hands between three different parties across the last five Tamil Nadu Assembly elections.



16th Kerala Assembly to have 11 women MLAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The 16th Kerala Legislative Assembly will have 11 women MLAs, one less than in the previous House. The outgoing Assembly had 12 women legislators, a majority of them from the CPI(M). CPI(M) legislator Kanathil Jameela passed away in November last year.

This time, the CPI(M) will have only one woman MLA-O S Ambika, who won from Attungal by a margin of 13,375 votes.

CPI, an LDF ally, will have one woman MLA compared to two in the previous Assembly, with Geetha Gopi winning from Nattika by 7,093 votes.

The Congress, which swept the election, accounts for the highest number of women MLAs in the new Assembly.

Shanimol Osman won from



Aroor by 9,324 votes, while Ramya Haridas won from Chirayinkeezhu by 1,422 votes.

Congress candidate Vidya Balakrishnan won from Elathur, defeating minister AK Saseendran by 12,162 votes.

Congress leader Bindhu Krishna won from Kollam by 16,830 votes. Thulasi Teacher won from Kongad by 3,706 votes, and Uma Thomas won from Thirikkakara by 50,211 votes.

Congress leader Usha Vijayan won from Mananthavady after defeating minister OR Kulu by 10,543 votes.

The Indian Union Muslim League will have a woman MLA this time after Fathima Thahiliya won from Perambra by 5,087 votes. In addition, KK Rema of the RMP, a UDF ally, retained her seat from Vadakara by 14,862 votes. The Assembly elections in Kerala were held on April 9.

TVK may form alliance with AIADMK: DMK MP Kalanidhi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

DMK MP Dr Kalanidhi Veeraswami said on Monday that to form a government, TVK chief Vijay would possibly form an alliance with AIADMK.

Speaking to reporters after meeting with Chief Minister MK Stalin and others at DMK headquarters, Anna Arivalayam here, Veeraswami said: “This is going to be a hung assembly. So we have to see how it’s going to pan out. Whether AIADMK is going to be supporting them (TVK), we’ll have to wait and watch.”

DMK MP Kanimozhi told

reporters that her party chief had always reiterated that people’s verdict must be accepted gracefully.

“And we will have to retrospectively see what we have to do in the future. And whoever has voted, we will definitely work for them,” she said.

The TVK is likely to form a Government.

According to the Election Commission website, TVK has won 90 seats and is leading in 12 seats. Similarly, the AIADMK has won 42 seats and is leading in five seats. The DMK has won 50 seats and is leading in 10 seats. Elections to 234 Assembly seats were held on April 23.



Voters ignore NOTA: Fails to cross 1% in most States

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

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startups have turned unicorns, while some took time, others failed to leave an imprint.

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The TVK from the start created a strong buzz, and with several political ‘startups’ formed by movie stars doing well in the past in the South, there were high expectations from it in the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls. The TVK has stunned one and all, causing a major political earth-

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Kerala voters’ trust in us will guide UDF: Priyanka Gandhi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

With the Congress-led UDF bagging a major win in the Kerala polls, Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Monday thanked the people of the State for their overwhelming support and vowed to work diligently towards building a better future for them.

In a post on X, Gandhi said, “To all my brothers and sisters in Keralam, thank you for your faith and for your overwhelming support. The trust you have placed in us will be the UDF’s guiding force as we work hard towards building a better future for each one of you.”

“I sincerely hope that our gratitude to you will be evident each day of the next five years as we strive to fulfil our commitments to you with honesty and humility,” she added.

“To my family in Wayanad, you have renewed your belief in the UDF with a resounding mandate — 7 out of 7 seats!!



Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi

You now have 8 representatives working together towards the development of Wayanad! We will do all we can to live up to your expectations,” the MP from Wayanad said.

“To the workers and leaders of the UDF who worked day and night to take our message of a united and progressive Keralam to every household, my heartiest congrat-

ulations, best wishes and gratitude for your tireless efforts,” Gandhi’s post read.

According to the Election Commission website, the UDF was leading or had won in over 95 constituencies and appears poised to secure a comfortable majority in the 140-member House. The UDF is set to form the Government after a decade of LDF rule in the State.



Editor's
TAKE

The verdict: BJP claims
Bengal, TVK pips DMK

May 4 was all about confirming the strengths and limits of political parties, and the verdict showed that claiming India in its entirety remains a distant goal

The biggest takeaway from the May 4 assembly results is that TMC has been dislodged by the BJP, finally. After three terms, Mamata Banerjee has been ousted by the BJP. Yet another surprise came from down south where Vijay-led Tamilaaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) dislodged the well-entrenched Stalin-led DMK. Both these results are significant from the national perspective and they will have far-reaching implications for the national politics and next general elections. The May 4 verdict yet again confirmed that Indian politics continues to have a double track – a national perspective which is predominant in the North and a regional narrative that sways voters in the South; this is the narrative which speaks to regional identities and southern issues. A few results have been on expected lines. In Assam, the BJP retained power. The party has been going strong since 2016. It has successfully fused identity politics with governance.

The party under Himanta Biswa Sarma has executed welfare schemes, undertaken infrastructure projects that resonated with the voters. He also tactfully calibrated issues like migration and citizenship, which have helped it consolidate support across communities. The leadership of Himanta Biswa Sarma has further sharpened this appeal, combining administrative visibility with political messaging.

West Bengal, however, tells a more complex story. The defeat of Mamata Banerjee and the ouster of the All India Trinamool Congress (TMC) that came to power in 2011 show the efforts the BJP put in and the anti-incumbency Mamata faced.

Bengal had accumulated grievances – ranging from corruption allegations to concerns about political violence and governance issues, which the voters addressed in their two phase voting. The BJP's rise here is less about ideological conversion and more about discontentment with the Mamata style of functioning. Yet, the scale and durability of this shift will only be tested over time. The southern states, meanwhile played to the Dravidian script, though the third force led by Vijay that appeared recently outsmarted MK Stalin. Thanks to his mass appeal and well-articulate messaging, Vijay became the number one choice of the voters; of course the anti-incumbency and plethora of mis-governance and corruption charges against the Stalin government helped him dislodge the Tamil Nadu stalwart. In Kerala, power alternated once again, with the United Democratic Front (UDF) displacing the Left Democratic Front (LDF). These outcomes underline the persistence of strong regional political cultures and linguistic identities that have kept the BJP at bay in the south. Despite organisational efforts and growing vote share in a few pockets, the party remains a peripheral player. The broader implication is clear: the BJP's strength across large parts of the north, west, and northeast contrasts with its limited footprint in the south.

Meanwhile, regional parties continue to hold ground in their bastions, but the Bengal result shows that anti-incumbency, if left unaddressed, can swiftly alter political equations. These results show that India votes in layers and no one can take Indian voters for granted!

A historic dawn: The 2026 mandate for
governance, culture, and pro-incumbency

We salute the people of Bengal, Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, and Tamil Nadu. We offer our heartfelt congratulations to every BJP and NDA worker who toiled tirelessly to make this victory possible



SYED ZAFAR
ISLAM

May 4th, 2026, was a day of great joy, deep gratitude, and overwhelming emotion. As the election results of 2026 unfolded before us, my heart swelled with pride as I watched the democratic spirit of our great nation roar in favour of development, stability, and cultural revival. This wasn't just an electoral victory; it was a massive validation of the sweat and blood our karyakartas have poured into the grassroots over the years.

The absolute crown jewel of this historic moment is undoubtedly West Bengal. This was not a standard political contest; it was a direct battle between the resilient people of Bengal and the cruel Trinamool Congress. And the people have won. They are not just winning by a narrow margin; they have delivered a crushing, almost two-thirds majority. The absolute majority we are securing is a glorious victory for the identity of Bengal, the restoration of democratic values, and the immense sacrifices of our dedicated workers.

For fifteen years, the citizens of Bengal suffocated under a regime that normalised violence, institutionalised corruption, and unleashed a dreaded 'Syndicate Raj'. The massive mandate is a reflection of the deep-rooted frustration people harboured against the TMC. Ordinary Bengalis saw neither development nor dignity in this period. But now, the people have uprooted this autocracy through their vote.

Women have been the pioneers of this historic transformation. The horrific scars left by incidents like Sandeshkhali and RG Kar were answered not with helpless tears, but with the silent, devastating power of the EVM. Despite the unimaginable harassment faced by the RG Kar victim's mother, the women of Bengal responded with a powerful mandate for safety and dignity. Our mothers and sisters have united to show unwavering faith in our leadership.

Let us remember the journey: in 2001, we were at 0. In 2016, we won 3 seats. In 2021, we rose to 77 seats and became the principal opposition. And now, in 2026, the BJP is forming the government in Bengal. This is nothing short of a miracle, but it is a miracle born of years of sacrifice by our workers, relentless struggle, and the trust the people have placed in Prime Minister Modi's vision.

It is more important to note what Mamata Banerjee offered this time. No 'report card' of fifteen years in power. Her entire campaign was



THIS MANDATE
CARRIES ONE
CLEAR MESSAGE:
WHETHER IT IS
BENGAL, ASSAM,
KERALA,
PUDUCHERRY, OR
TAMIL NADU,
WHEREVER THE
BJP AND NDA
HAVE EARNED
THE PEOPLE'S
TRUST, THE
PEOPLE HAVE
RESPONDED
WITH
OVERWHELMING
SUPPORT

The writer is National
Spokesperson, BJP, and a
former Member of the
Rajya Sabha

dailypioneer
 @syedzafarBJP
 The Pioneer

limited to abusing the BJP, inflaming the Hindi-Bengali divide, and shielding the corrupt. She even brought in people from other states to campaign for her. But nothing worked.

For years, the TMC insulted Sanatan Dharma, hurt Hindu sentiments, and weaponised appeasement politics. TMC ministers openly threatened Hindus in order to appease their vote bank. The people of Bengal have made it clear: those who disrespect Sanatan will not be accepted in Bengal.

Looking towards the Northeast, Assam stands out as the ultimate masterclass in governance. Assam is a classic example of how a BJP government fundamentally transforms a state and builds an unbreakable bond of trust with its people. What we see here is the glorious victory of 'pro-incumbency', a phenomenon where voters actively reward good performance. In all three terms, our government in Assam has been formed with progressively greater support from the public. In this third consecutive term, we are forming the government with an unprecedented more than three-fourths majority. The people of Assam have firmly backed the 'Double-Engine' growth and the decisive actions taken against illegal infiltration. In BJP-governed states, voters do not turn against the government; they reaffirm their trust in it, because we make promises and we keep them. Every single one. While the opposition chose to shield infiltrators, the citizens chose a government committed to protecting their civilisation and driving infrastructure growth.

Down south, Kerala is witnessing an altogether new beginning. We have established ourselves as a strong choice in Kerala. We have won 3 seats, and history reminds us that the number '3' is incredibly lucky for us. Just as we once started with 3 seats in Bengal in 2016, jumped to 77 in

the next term, and are now sweeping the state to form the government, Kerala is on the same trajectory. The Lotus has now been seeded and is ready to bloom soon. In the upcoming tenures, we will form the government for sure.

In Puducherry, the mandate for continuity is clear as day. We are proudly forming the government for the second consecutive term, proving that the stability provided by the NDA resonates deeply with the public. The journey towards a developed territory continues uninterrupted.

In Tamil Nadu, while we humbly accept the mandate and recognise that we must work harder on the ground, there is a massive silver lining. The DMK's crushing defeat in Tamil Nadu sends a thunderous message: "Insult to Sanatan will NOT be tolerated by India." The rejection of Chief Minister MK Stalin and Udhayanidhi Stalin makes it crystal clear: the people of Tamil Nadu have completely cast aside those who abuse Sanatan, those who obstruct the path of Deepam, and those who try to divide the nation in the name of region and language.

While we celebrate this beautiful festival of democracy, the state of the principal opposition is truly pathetic. At a time when election results are unfolding and their defeated leaders desperately need moral support, Rahul Gandhi is completely missing from the battlefield. Instead

of standing with his cadre, he is away on a foreign visit, as always. A leader who does not stand beside his workers in the hour of crisis, who abandons his party's leaders and ground-level workers

on this decisive moment to travel abroad-how can such a person aspire to lead the people of India? Another feather in his crown is his completion of a century of defeats. This glaring absence proves why the nation has decisively chosen our relentless dedication over the irresponsible leadership of the Congress party.

This mandate carries one clear message: whether it is Bengal, Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, or Tamil Nadu, wherever the BJP and NDA have earned the people's trust, the people have responded with overwhelming support. Across these five states, only the BJP and NDA retained their governments, returning with even greater support. This is not merely an electoral victory. It is the people of India placing their seal of approval on 'Modi's Guarantee.'

We salute the people of Bengal, Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, and Tamil Nadu. We offer our heartfelt congratulations to every BJP and NDA worker who toiled tirelessly to make this victory possible. We now take the pledge to serve with even greater responsibility and dedication, to live up to every expectation the people have placed in us. 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas' — this is our mantra, and this is our path forward.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIC TALK



A squirrel feeds on a blooming Gulmohar flower on a tree branch, in New Delhi.

PHOTO: PTI

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Why do some people remain intensely apolitical?



ASHA IYER
KUMAR

2ND
OPINION

My aged mother, living in one of the six states that went to the Assembly polls, was unsure if she would cast her ballot this time because of poor health. However, members of a certain party made arrangements for her commute to the polling booth, where she was told she could not vote. She had misplaced her Aadhaar card, and that stopped her from participating in the democratic process she had rarely missed. Yet she was not disappointed, for, in her words, "it doesn't matter who comes to power. They are all the same."

She and my late father had an allegiance to the Congress party and would show support to the "hand" regardless of who the candidate was. It had little to do with the party's ideology; they were not concerned about what the party had come to be. Their loyalty was rooted

in history. For many people like me, national politics is not a staple. It is something we encounter in passing, in fragments-like news playing in a waiting room. For those who are deeply political, this may seem like indifference towards democracy or a lack of conviction about our right to choose how we are governed. It is not so. For many who consider themselves apolitical, the distance arises from confusion, disillusionment, and fatigue.

It brings to mind George Orwell's Animal Farm, where the promise of equality and justice slowly slips into moral compromise, exposing the decay within political systems. In recent times, we have seen new entrants like AAP promise clean governance and change. Yet, over time, principles appear diluted amid accusations and defections, leading to crises of credibility.

This raises a difficult question: is clean governance, or even change itself, sustainable in a world that quietly prioritises self-interest over public good? The recurring cycle of hope and disappointment reinforces the belief that "all are the same", keeping many at a distance from political engagement.

At the same time, we live in an era where a film star can become a political force almost overnight — not necessarily because of governance credentials, but due to

mass appeal. Vijay's entry into politics in Tamil Nadu reflects this ongoing fusion of cinema and politics. Whether this marks a meaningful shift or simply adds to the spectacle remains to be seen.

For many citizens, what matters most is stability. Who governs is less important than how governance affects daily life. People care about whether their lives become easier, safer, and more secure. Ideology matters, but only when it translates into tangible outcomes. Without that, party names and positions lose significance.

Being ideologically neutral does not mean being uninformed or indifferent. For many, it is not an absence of thought but a refusal to be confined by rigid political identities. Parties demand alignment, but individuals often live with contradictions. One can value secularism while also advocating equality; these are not mutually exclusive.

When political systems force binary choices, those who prefer nuance often step back-not from issues, but from the pressure to conform. They are not anti-political, merely less vocal. They understand that thoughtful engagement does not always need to be loud or polarised.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist, independent journalist and children's writing coach

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

NOTIFIABLE STATUS FOR LEPROSY CAN
IMPROVE EARLY DETECTION

Apropos "Government set to declare leprosy a notifiable disease" (*The Pioneer*, May 2), Delhi will become the sixth state after Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Uttarakhand to make the disease notifiable. This step will strengthen surveillance, help control transmission, enable early diagnosis, improve treatment compliance, and reduce stigma. Effective management of leprosy, along with ensuring free drugs to the needy, could be significantly bolstered by this move.

Leprosy is a chronic disease which, if diagnosed and treated promptly, can be completely cured. Notification should promote easier access to drugs for all patients. Although India was declared a "leprosy-free"

country in 2005, in line with World Health Organisation standards of less than one case per 10,000 population, the disease continues to be reported in several parts of the country. Making it notifiable will require every doctor treating a patient to report the case to the district leprosy officer, ensuring proper monitoring and follow-up.

The remaining states should follow the example set by Delhi and the five others in making leprosy notifiable.

The WHO has strongly recommended including the disease in the notifiable list to improve public health outcomes. Such a coordinated approach will be crucial in moving closer to the complete eradication of leprosy in India.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Reels craze turns deadly

An adventure turned into a horrifying misadventure for a team of five youngsters in Uttar Pradesh's Siddharth Nagar, who climbed atop a water tank to shoot reels, once again reminds us how today's youth ignore precautions and risk their precious lives for social media attention.

The accident occurred when the stairs collapsed and three children fell from the structure, killing one, seriously injuring two, and leaving two others stranded atop the tank. They were later rescued in a joint operation involving the fire department and the Indian Air Force, which airlifted them to safety. Present-day youth love adventure, challenges, and new horizons. However, it is alarming that in their quest to make an impression, many chase reels and selfies, often risking their lives by attempting dangerous feats. What they forget is the fatal risk involved in such actions, endangering not only themselves but also causing immense distress to their families. Parents and teachers have a vital role to play and must guide them to avoid such life-threatening risks. A reckless attempt to film social media reels atop a water tank in Siddharth Nagar turned tragic, exposing how the youth's pursuit of online attention often comes at the cost of safety and life.

M PRADYU | KANNUR

When development destroys nature

Industrialisation cannot be allowed to bulldoze ecological truth, especially in a fragile and irreplaceable region like the Nicobar Islands. These islands are not empty land banks waiting for corporate occupation; they are living, breathing ecosystems rich in biodiversity, deeply rooted indigenous cultures, and nature's own defence against climate catastrophe.

Yes, development is necessary. But a model of growth that destroys forests, uproots indigenous communities, and weakens climate resilience is not development; it is exploitation legitimised by policy and powered by profit.

When voices rise against deforestation, they are not obstacles-they are the conscience of democracy. Silencing them is not governance; it is the erosion of accountability. True democracy thrives not on blind approval, but on informed resistance. The forests of the Nicobar Islands are not expendable assets. They are shields against cyclones and rising seas, lifelines for indigenous communities, reservoirs of rare flora and fauna, and pillars of ecological balance. To justify deforestation in the name of industrialisation is to gamble recklessly with our collective future. When forests fall, civilisations do not rise — they collapse.

BRUHASPATI SAMAL | BHUBANESWAR

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Diplomacy needs responsible language

US President Donald Trump recently reposted on social media a commentary by American radio host Michael Savage, in which Savage described India and China as "hellholes". India rightly termed the post "uninformed, inappropriate and in poor taste" — a rather mild response to such offensive language. Trump ought to exercise greater caution in his public remarks. The US President has frequently used outlandish language to describe foreign nations and leaders. Recently, he also targeted Canada, a long-standing ally. In early 2026, he criticised Prime Minister Mark Carney, calling him "ungrateful" and claiming Canada depended entirely on the United States. Carney responded firmly, stating that Canada "thrives because we are Canadian".

Trump's remarks on Greenland and his rhetoric following the death of Ali Khamenei further strained global sensitivities. His aggressive posturing, alongside actions involving Benjamin Netanyahu, has drawn criticism worldwide. Even Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva cautioned that Trump was "not elected to be emperor of the world".

Such language undermines diplomacy and global respect.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KOZHIKODE

The forgotten martyrs: India’s forest guards are dying to save the forests

There is no uniform, no applause, and often no backup. Deep inside India’s forests, far from public view, frontline foresters — guards, rangers, and wardens — fight a relentless war against timber smugglers, mining mafias, and armed poachers, even as they confront wild animals and unforgiving terrain



VK BAHUGUNA

Forest protection is becoming a real challenge for frontline field foresters like Forest Guards, Rangers, and Wildlife Wardens in view of emerging, well-coordinated mafias with the latest superior weaponry. Over the last 30 to 35 years, thousands of forest personnel have lost their lives to protect natural resources all over the world. India is frequently cited by the International Ranger Federation (IRF) as the most dangerous country for foresters. In a typical three-year period, IRF statistics have shown that India accounts for nearly 30-40 per cent of all global forester deaths. India has the highest number of forest staff fatalities in the world, with reports highlighting hundreds of injuries and deaths in the line of duty. Between 2012 and 2017, India accounted for nearly 31 per cent (162) of the 526 forest ranger deaths reported globally. Compared to this, between 2006 and 2021, the IRF recorded approximately 2,351 casualties across 82 countries.

Thus, thousands of foresters’ lives are lost in the line of duty due to attacks by timber smugglers and poachers; conflicts with elephants, tigers, leopards, and other wild animals during patrolling; and occupational hazards such as forest fires, malaria, and water-borne diseases. Not only frontline staff but also senior IFS officers like DFOs, Conservators, and National Park Directors have been killed in India.

P Srinivas, a 1979 IFS officer, who was beheaded by the sandalwood smuggler Veerappan in 1992, is now an icon of civil service sacrifice for the sake of duty, and at the Lal Bahadur Shastri Academy and other such academies, a P Srinivas Memorial Lecture is arranged every year during the foundation course of civil servants by the Government of India. P Srinivas was awarded the Kirti Chakra for his sacrifice. Similarly, Sanjay Singh, a 1992 batch IFS officer and DFO Rohtas, was killed by Maoists in February 2002.

Apart from foresters, large numbers of local people are also killed by wild animals in conflicts. Over the last 25 years, 1,296 people were killed by animals, mostly in recent years. In Uttarakhand alone, during 2025, 40 people were killed by leopards and 72 were attacked by bears. In this article, however, I want to discuss more about the problems of forest department staff because, if remedial measures are taken, then attacks on locals will also be reduced.

Members of the IFS, as also other ranks, work in difficult areas where civic facilities are poor, and they have to battle organised timber and mining mafias and well-equipped wildlife poachers with very primitive tools, while the mafias are equipped with advanced gadgets and weapons. When personnel are killed or seriously injured, they are left to their own fate, and their families suffer ignominiously. Compensation from state governments is poor, delayed, and sometimes ignored completely.

The Indian Forest Service Association (IFS) took note of the pitiable conditions of such personnel and constituted the Indian Forest Service Benevolent and Welfare Trust (IFSBWT) to bridge that gap with immediate financial relief and to complement the support extended by the states. Initially, this was meant for IFS officers but has now been made applicable to all categories of forest personnel in the country.

The Trust was originally established in July 2008 by a group of Indian Forest Service officers in Delhi as a public charitable trust under the provisions of the Registration Act, 1908, so that bereaved families of IFS officers who die in harness can be assisted. Recently, it has been noted that largely frontline forestry personnel are killed or grievously injured while attempting to stop illegal mining, smuggling, encroachment, and poaching across several states; therefore, in January 2026, the Trust substantially widened its scope to include all frontline staff, as the majority of casualties and injuries occur mainly among Foresters, Guards, and Watchers, who are the real green warriors at the delivery point and the only line of defence for the country’s forests.

Supporting these frontline warriors and their families was therefore made the foremost priority of



the Trust. Accordingly, the Trust was re-registered on February 11, 2026, with an expanded mandate covering all categories of forestry field personnel in the country, from IFS officers to Forest Guards and below.

Notwithstanding the attempts by the IFS Central Association, society and government must take the lead to ameliorate the pitiable working conditions under which Forest Guards, Foresters, and Rangers have to work in a hostile environment, which is more often than not made vicious by the political patronage of mafias, especially the mining mafia.

To address this issue and improve the welfare of “Green Soldiers”, concrete measures need to be taken. First and foremost is to vest frontline staff with legal powers by granting forest officers the authority for the “minimal and proportionate use of force”, similar to the police, to deter organised crime such as sand, timber, and poacher mafias.

Further legal protection should be provided against frivolous counter-complaints filed by offenders to harass forest staff. Amend state rules to provide Section 187 of BNSS protection to all field staff, ensuring they cannot be prosecuted for actions taken in the line of duty without prior government sanction. Second, provide modern and effective firearms and tactical training to field staff working in high-conflict zones so they are not outgunned by poachers.

Third, provide financial and social security by ensuring a minimum uniform ex gratia of at least ₹50 lakh for unnatural deaths in the line of duty across all states, and continuing their last drawn salary for the family of the deceased until the retirement date. In addition, the government must extend schemes like the PM Scholarship for children of deceased armed forces personnel to the children of forest martyrs.

Next is to ensure better infrastructure for frontline staff, as in the police, by improving remote forest beats with basic amenities such as potable water, electricity, and high-quality field gear like satellite phones, fast-moving, good-quality vehicles, drones, night vision, GPS, etc. A Forest Housing Corporation should be established in each state with 100 per cent grants from the Central Government on the same pattern as in the police department. Immediate access to emergency medical support and air evacuation for staff injured in remote areas must also be ensured.

Last but not least is to institute the President’s Green Gallantry Medals specifically for foresters, on a par with police or military medals, to boost morale and public respect for the service.

On the organisational front, it is necessary to separate protection and enforcement from development and silviculture. States need to create dedicated anti-poaching and protection units at the division level.

These teams should consist of physically fit, tactically trained personnel whose only job is patrolling and enforcement, leaving plantation and other work to a separate administrative wing. States also need to create an intelligence wing at the range level to build an intelligence network.

The Ministry of Environment and Forests needs to take up these suggestions on a war footing, as the country’s ecological warriors can only be neglected at the peril of destabilising food, water, and ecological stability.



THE MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT AND FORESTS NEEDS TO TAKE UP THESE SUGGESTIONS ON A WAR FOOTING, AS THE COUNTRY’S ECOLOGICAL WARRIORS CAN ONLY BE NEGLECTED AT THE PERIL OF DESTABILISING FOOD, WATER, AND ECOLOGICAL STABILITY

The writer is former Principal Secretary Government of Tripura and Chairman of Centre for Resource Management

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The mindshifts behind Ujjwala’s decade of change



NIDHI PRABHA TEWARI

As Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana completes a decade, its relevance goes beyond its metrics. For policymakers elsewhere, the key question is not just what was achieved, but how a system constrained by inertia began to move at scale. The answer lies in a set of fundamental mindshifts — what the Causing Incredible Performance framework calls Reset Mind: identifying and altering the thoughts that limit action. Ujjwala shows that when the way a problem is seen changes, execution follows-offering a practical lens for large-scale policy design.

1. From scarcity to abundance
For decades, clean cooking fuel was treated as a scarce, urban-oriented resource. Access was rationed

and expansion cautious. Ujjwala flipped this. It operated from a stance of abundance-that clean energy access could be expanded rapidly and equitably. This enabled a shift from incrementalism to ambition, from “how much can we give” to “how many should we reach”. Scale became possible because the mental ceiling was lifted before the operational one.

2. From ‘available biomass’ to valued outcomes
In rural contexts, biomass was seen as a sufficient basis for cooking energy. Improved cookstoves and biogas were promoted, but adoption remained limited. Ujjwala forced a more fundamental question: what outcomes matter-time saved, health improved, dignity enhanced?

Reframing the issue in terms of outcomes made it possible to see LPG not as a replacement for tradition, but as an enabler of new choices. Biomass, in turn, could be used differently.

3. From inevitability to intentionality
A persistent belief in large systems is that change will happen gradually-through rising incomes or education. Yet before Ujjwala, LPG adoption in rural areas remained slow.

PMUY shifted this from passive expectation to deliberate action-setting ambitious goals, mobilising supply chains, and driving adoption with urgency. This move-from inevitability to intentionality-explains the leap from stagnation to visible change.

4. From untargeted subsidies to smarter targeting
A key hesitation was whether another subsidised scheme would strain public finances.

Prior groundwork through PAHAL-direct benefit transfer, de-duplication, and better targeting-enabled more prudent subsidy management. This helped address fiscal concerns while enabling expansion at scale.

5. From doubts about readiness to confident adoption
Safety concerns were real: would first-time users-often in fire-prone homes-handle LPG safely? LPG expands nearly 250 times when released, creating a flammable cloud.

What followed challenged this assumption. As households adopted LPG, they learned to use it safely. Oil marketing companies invested in user education, and the widespread presence of the red cylinder built shared community knowledge. Along with a robust product, this enabled a shift from fear to confident adoption.



6. From affordability concerns to gradual adoption
Affordability was another concern: would households pay for refills, especially when women are not always decision-makers? Should cheaper alternatives come first? Ujjwala resisted creating a lower-tier product, offering instead the same LPG system used by the middle class.

Adoption has been gradual. Many households began using LPG selectively-during illness, for guests, or in adverse weather-before integrating it into daily cooking. Others transitioned faster; some still face constraints. Over time, LPG has found a place in household budgets. Refill rates have risen from about 3 to around 5 cylinders annually, supported by smaller cylinders, financing options, and better last-mile delivery.

Conclusion: Policy as a function of perception
These shifts point to something deeper than a successful scheme: policy outcomes are shaped by the thoughts that precede them.

The scale and direction of Ujjwala were driven by a decisive shift in thinking at the highest levels. Leadership from PM Shri Narendra Modi and the then Petroleum Minister Shri Dharmendra Pradhan helped reframe clean cooking as a national priority anchored in dignity and access. This reset was carried forward by public sector oil marketing companies, their distributor networks, and frontline functionaries, along with women on the ground, who translated intent into execution.

It also reframed women from passive beneficiaries to customers, raising expectations and improving service delivery.

As India designs future interventions-in energy, health, or livelihoods-the lesson is clear: execution improves when perception shifts. The goal is not to prescribe a single path, but to understand which interventions deliver faster, larger, and more valued outcomes-and under what conditions.

The writer is a public policy practitioner and co-founder of Athulya Performance Facilitators, where she works with public leaders on achieving results at scale. She has worked on the implementation of Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana for five years

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Defection by design: How the ‘merger’ clause is reshaping Parliament



ABHINAV K SHUKLA | ABHINAV NARAYAN JHA

A recent political development in the Rajya Sabha has once again exposed a constitutional paradox that has long remained under-examined. Seven Members of Parliament belonging to the Aam Aadmi Party-six representing Punjab and one representing Delhi-have shifted allegiance to the Bharatiya Janata Party. Numerically, this constitutes more than two-thirds of the party’s strength in the House, thereby attracting the “merger” exception under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution of India. Constitutionally, the recognition of this shift by the Chairperson is unassailable. Normatively, however, it raises a deeper question: has the law, in preserving stability, diluted representation?

The anti-defection framework, introduced through the 52nd Constitutional Amendment in 1985, was designed to combat political opportunism and ensure party discipline. It sought to prevent elected representatives from betraying the

mandate on which they were elected. Yet, it also carved out an exception: where not less than two-thirds of a legislature party agree to a merger, disqualification would not follow. This exception, found in Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule, was conceived as a pragmatic safeguard, recognising that political realignments at the party level may sometimes be legitimate.

However, what appears doctrinally sound begins to fray when tested against the institutional role of the Rajya Sabha. Unlike the directly elected lower house, the Rajya Sabha is not merely a chamber of political contestation; it is a federal institution. It is designed as the Council of States, a forum where states, through their indirectly elected representatives, participate in national law-making. Members are elected by state legislative assemblies, embedding within them a fiduciary obligation to articulate state-specific concerns in the Union legislature.

This design reflects a carefully calibrated constitutional vision. India may be described as a “Union of States”, but its parliamentary architecture ensures that states are not rendered voiceless in national decision-making. The Rajya Sabha acts as a deliberative check on the Lok Sabha, scrutinising legislation and, in many cases, serving as the final gatekeeper. No ordinary legislation can become law without its assent; constitutional amendments require its concurrence by a special majority. In matters affecting the federal balance, the Constitution goes even further, mandating ratification by at least half of the states under Article 368 of the Constitution of India.



Against this backdrop, the recent shift assumes a different character. Punjab sends seven members to the Rajya Sabha. These members were elected by a state legislature led by the Aam Aadmi Party, reflecting a particular political mandate within the state. Their role, therefore, extended beyond partisan alignment; they were expected to serve as the voice of Punjab in national deliberations, especially where central legislation might affect state interests.

When six out of these seven members realign with the ruling party at the Centre, a structural tension emerges. Can representatives, elected through one political mandate within a state, effectively discharge their representative function after aligning with a different political formation, particularly one that governs at the Union level?

More pointedly, can they meaningfully oppose or scrutinise the very executive they now politically support?

The anti-defection law offers a formal answer: yes. By treating such a shift as a “merger”, it immunises these members from disqualification. But this legal fiction-that a legislative supermajority necessarily reflects a genuine party merger-deserves closer scrutiny. In practice, what is being recognised is not always the merger of political parties at the organisational level, but rather the coordinated defection of legislators. The distinction is subtle but constitutionally significant.

The original intent behind the merger exception was to accommodate situations where an entire political party, as an organisational entity, decides to merge with another. The two-thirds threshold was introduced to address a practical concern: what if a faction of legislators resists such a decision? The Constitution sought to protect both collective political strategy and individual legislative autonomy. It did not intend to provide a route for large-scale defections that leave the original party structure intact but hollowed out within the legislature.

This is where the present episode becomes instructive. The constitutional mechanism has operated correctly; the outcome, however, appears to strain the spirit of the provision. What we witness is not merely a shift in party numbers, but a potential erosion of the federal voice that the Rajya Sabha is meant to embody.

The deeper concern, therefore, is institutional rather than partisan. If the composition of a state’s

representation in the Rajya Sabha can be effectively transformed mid-term through the merger exception, the link between state mandate and parliamentary voice becomes attenuated. The Council of States risks becoming, in effect, a chamber of shifting political loyalties rather than stable federal representation.

This is not to argue for an absolutist anti-defection regime. Political mobility and realignment are intrinsic to a democratic system. But when constitutional provisions designed for stability begin to undermine representational integrity, a recalibration becomes necessary. One possible approach is to revisit the interpretation of “merger” to require demonstrable organisational integration between parties, rather than merely a numerical threshold within the legislature. Another is to reconsider whether members elected to represent states should be held to a higher standard of accountability in cases of political realignment.

Ultimately, the question is not whether the law has been followed-it has. The question is whether the law, as currently structured and interpreted, continues to serve the constitutional vision it was meant to uphold. In the quiet arithmetic of two-thirds, we may be witnessing the gradual dilution of something far more substantive: the voice of the states in India’s parliamentary democracy.

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Order Order

SC seeks Centre’s response on plea seeking filling of vacancies in Armed Forces Tribunal

Taking note of vacancies in the Armed Forces Tribunal, the Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea seeking to complete the process of selection and fill the vacant posts in a time-bound manner.

While agreeing to hear the petition, a bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked Attorney General R Venkataramani to assist it in the matter. The bench told the counsel appearing for the petitioner – Armed Forces Tribunal Bar Association (Regional Bench) – to hand over the petition to the office of the attorney general.

The bench posted the matter for hearing after two weeks. The advocate appearing for the petitioner said out of the 11 benches of the Armed Forces Tribunal (AFT), only three would be functional by the end of the year if the vacancies were not filled.



Thane man acquitted in kidnap & rape case; court cites victim’s consent

A Thane court has acquitted a 27-year-old man in a kidnapping and rape case, noting that the victim was an adult and had accompanied him voluntarily.

As the victim was a major, she was competent to make her own decisions, Special POC SO Court Judge Ruby U Malvankar said in the order on April 24, a copy of which was made available on Monday.

An FIR was registered on January 25, 2020, against Shashikapur Shyamal Gupta, a resident of Kalwa in Maharashtra's Thane city, on a complaint by the victim's father, alleging that his 16-year-old daughter was kidnapped from their home in the same area.

The police subsequently traced the girl and the accused to Azamgarh, Uttar Pradesh, where the couple claimed they had married in a temple before moving to Surat in Gujarat. The man faced charges under sections 363 (kidnapping), 376 (rape), and 506 (criminal intimidation) of the Indian Penal Code, and provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.



SC asks Lok Sabha MP to approach Patna HC with request to list his pending petition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday granted liberty to Lok Sabha MP Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav to approach the Patna High Court requesting it to list his pending petition seeking upgradation of his security cover from 'Y' to 'Z' category.

Yadav, a sitting MP from Bihar's Purnia constituency, has sought upgradation of his security cover citing alleged threats from gangster Lawrence Bishnoi's gang.

His counsel told a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi that the High Court had on November 19, 2024 issued notice on Yadav's plea



seeking upgradation of his security cover but neither that order was uploaded nor the matter was listed for hearing.

"Do you need 'Z' category security?" the bench asked his counsel.

Yadav's counsel said the MP has received threats from



SC slams Registry for not issuing notice to ED

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a rare and scathing rebuke of its own back-office, the Supreme Court on Monday lashed out at the apex court Registry, terming its conduct "nasty" and saying its officials think they are acting as "super Chief Justice of India".

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi made the observation while hearing a bail plea filed by Ayushi Mittal alias Ayushi Agarwal, an accused in an alleged investment fraud to the tune of more than ₹37,000 crore.

The CJI referred to an order passed on March 23 on the

plea, and wondered how the registry officials construed that the bench did not issue notice to the Enforcement Directorate and other respondents on the plea.

"The registry is acting very nasty," the CJI said, adding, "Very nasty registry. Each one sitting here considers themselves as super Chief Justice of India."

The bench in its fresh order said, "Notice has not been issued to the ED director stating no such order was passed. Let a fact finding inquiry be undertaken by the registrar judicial (of the apex court) as to how our March 23 order does not mean notice to the ED. Let notice be served to



the Directorate of Enforcement." The petitioner, Ayushi Mittal, her husband, and their company are accused of orchestrating a

crores of rupees remain in bank accounts currently frozen by the ED.

In its March 23 order, the bench had allowed an oral prayer by the counsel for the Rajasthan Government, a party in the case, to make the ED a party to the proceedings.

The purpose was to determine whether all movable and immovable assets belonging to the petitioner and her extended family had been properly attached.

The bench reiterated that it would not consider the merits of the bail plea until a "comprehensive description" of assets is provided.

It had ordered the petitioner's legal representative to

file an exhaustive affidavit detailing the immovable properties owned by the petitioner, her husband, their children and parents and siblings and parents-in-law.

It also sought details of assets of the company directors, managers, and key staff members. "Until such complete details are provided, we will not consider the plea for bail on its merits," the bench had said.

The registrar judicial has been tasked with investigating the administrative lapse within the Registry to identify why the court's previous instructions were ignored.

The bench said it will list the plea sometime in May.

Engineer Rashid moves HC to modify interim bail order

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Baramulla MP Sheikh Abdul Rashid alias Engineer Rashid on Monday urged the Delhi High Court to modify its earlier order granting him one-week interim bail in a terror funding case and allow him to be with his ailing father, who has been shifted to AIIMS Delhi from Srinagar.

A bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain, which had confined the Baramulla MP to Srinagar for the duration of his interim bail, listed the matter for hearing on Tuesday and asked him to furnish a local address.

The senior counsel for Rashid submitted that he has a flat in Delhi, which has been allotted to him as a member of Parliament. The court, however, observed that it would not permit Rashid to stay in a place that also houses other MPs.



"That is not good enough. You can't be in the MP house where other MPs are living. I can't permit that. It will be a security issue," the bench said.

The senior counsel said he would furnish the address of a private residence to the court.

The National Investigation Agency's (NIA) counsel submitted that since the court has effectively granted custody

parole in the matter and Rashid was no longer required to be outside Delhi, he should be permitted to visit his father from the jail itself, especially when the interim bail was expiring on May 6.

Custody parole entails a prisoner being escorted by armed police personnel to his place of visit.

The NIA lawyer further stated that the condition of the petitioner's father was stable and he was shifted to AIIMS Delhi on the family's request.

Rashid's counsel said that pursuant to the interim bail, he was released on April 30 and reached Srinagar the same day.

He said Rashid's father was airlifted to AIIMS Delhi after his health took a serious turn, but he was unable to relocate himself on account of the court order confining him to Srinagar.

"I am stuck in Srinagar. I am not allowed to come. He is here. I am there," the senior lawyer said.

HC junks SpiceJet’s plea to review ₹144 cr payment order in dispute with Maran

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday dismissed pleas by SpiceJet and its promoter Ajay Singh seeking a review of an earlier order to deposit ₹144 crore in connection with its legal dispute with media baron Kalanidhi Maran and Kal Airways.

Justice Subramonium Prasad also imposed cost of ₹50,000 on the airline and Singh. "Dismissed with cost of ₹50,000," the judge said while pronouncing the verdict.

On January 19, the court had directed SpiceJet and Singh to deposit ₹144 crore with the registry within six weeks



against an admitted liability of ₹194 crore. On March 18, time to make the deposit was extended by four weeks.

Singh and his budget airline sought reconsideration of the March 18 direction on several counts, including financial distress amid the ongoing

war in West Asia. SpiceJet instead offered a commercial property in Gurugram as security and informed the court that the Centre was willing to offer it some assistance.

Maran and Kal Airways opposed the review petitions,

saying the issues arising from financial distress had already been considered and rejected by the Supreme Court.

The matter arises from a dispute regarding the non-issuance of warrants in favour of Maran after the transfer of ownership to Singh, the controlling shareholder of SpiceJet.

The dispute started after Singh took back control of SpiceJet in February 2015 amid a financial crisis at the airline.

Maran and Kal Airways had transferred their entire 35.04 crore equity shares, amounting to a 58.46 per cent stake, in SpiceJet, to its co-founder, Singh, in February 2015 for just ₹2.

SC seeks report from Karnataka Govt on actor Darshan’s plea

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday sought a report from the Karnataka Government on a plea filed by actor Darshan, arrested in the Renukaswamy murder case, alleging he was being denied basic amenities like food in prison.

A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and R Mahadevan issued notice to the state Government on the actor's plea.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Darshan, submitted that the actor is being denied the basic amenities because the court had



made an observation that no five-star treatment should be given to him in jail.

"This is that case in which my Lords were pleased to cancel the bail of this petitioner, he was an actor..."

"Your Lordships made an observation in the order that he should not get five-star treatment in jail. Due to that direction, I am not even given basic ameni-

ties," he said. The top court had on August 14 last year cancelled the bail granted to Darshan and other accused persons in the case. Rohatgi submitted that the actor has been put in a quarantine cell, where there is no light and he is not getting food. The top court took note of the submission and sought a report from the judge on the status of the trial.

"We would like to know how many witnesses have been examined and how many witnesses the State proposes to examine. We would also like to have a fair idea of how much time the trial court is likely to take before it is concluded.

SC agrees to hear pleas against Transgender Persons Rights Amendment Act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from the Centre, all States and Union territories on a batch of pleas challenging the constitutional validity of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026.

A bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi agreed to hear the pleas and issued notice on them.



The bench said the matter would be placed before a three-judge bench, which would be constituted by the CJI. "There is no question of granting any interim order," it said. The apex court posted the matter for hearing after six weeks.

On March 25, Parliament passed a bill to amend the law on the protection and rights of transgender persons, which excludes social orientations from the ambit of the statute. It received the President's assent on March 30. The Act provides for graded punishment based on the gravity of harm inflicted on such people.

SC agrees to hear AgustaWestland middleman James’ plea for release from jail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to hear the plea of alleged middleman Christian Michel James in the ₹3,600-crore AgustaWestland VVIP chopper scam case seeking his release from jail.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta issued notice to the Centre, Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and sought their response in four weeks.

James has challenged Article 17 of the treaty, signed in 1999, which allows the requesting state (in this case India) to prosecute extradited persons not only for the

specific offence for which extradition was done, but also for connected offences.

At the outset, counsel appearing for James submitted that the High Court has gone to the extent of saying that the treaty between India and UAE will prevail over any existing law.

"I had filed a writ petition (before the High Court) challenging this portion of the treaty," the counsel submitted.

The bench said it has issued notice on the plea and the matter will be listed in July.

On April 24, the top court referred to another bench a plea of James for release from jail in the case.

The Delhi High Court had

on April 8 dismissed the petition of the British national in the case, saying there was no merit in the plea of James who was extradited from Dubai in December 2018.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi had taken note of the fact that the earlier pleas of the accused were heard by another bench headed by Justice Nath and referred the matter.

In his petition, James assailed a provision of the India-UAE extradition treaty. He also challenged a trial court order of August 7, 2025 by which his application under Section 436A of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) for his release from jail



was rejected. It was argued before the High Court that an extradited person can be prosecuted only for the offences for which extradition took place, and not for connected offences.

James, in its petition, also submitted that he completed

seven years in jail on December 4, 2025 and has, therefore, already undergone the maximum sentence possible for the offences for which he was extradited, rendering his continued detention in India illegal.

The High Court, in his

order, stated that it was not permissible for James to re-agitate issues pertaining to the treaty which, at least on a prima facie basis, have already been considered by the Supreme Court.

It nonetheless considered provisions of the treaty and ruled that James was extradited for facing trial for offences which directly arises from the factual background in the present case, and therefore, his prosecution fell within the scope of the treaty.

After his extradition, James was arrested by the CBI and the ED.

James is among the three alleged middlemen being probed in the case, and the other two are Guido Haschke and Carlo Gerosa.

He was granted bail by the Supreme Court in the CBI case in February 2025. The High Court granted him bail in the ED case in March that year.

James, however, continues to be in jail as he was unable to fulfil the bail conditions.

A trial court directed James to furnish a personal bond of ₹5 lakh and a cash surety of the same amount to secure his release in the CBI case. In the ED case, the High Court asked him to furnish a personal bond of ₹5 lakh and a cash surety of ₹10 lakh.

The High Court also clarified that James could be released without depositing the passport, which has expired immediately.

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Stock markets rebound, Sensex rallies 356 pts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Benchmark Sensex rebounded by 356 points, while the Nifty settled above 24,100 on Monday, as buying in blue-chip stocks and state poll results trending in line with market expectations lifted investor sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 355.90 points or 0.46 per cent to settle at 77,269.40. During the day, it jumped 997.25 points or 1.29 per cent to 77,910.75.

The 50-share NSE Nifty rallied 121.75 points or 0.51 per cent to end at 24,119.30.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Adani Ports, Hindustan Unilever, Reliance Industries, Larsen & Toubro, Eternal and Maruti were among the biggest gainers.

Bharti Airtel, Kotak Mahindra Bank, Tata Consultancy Services and ITC were among the laggards from the pack.

Top Gainers	%	Top Losers	%
Adani Ports	5.30	Bharti Airtel	-3.14
Hind Unilever	2.60	Kotak Bank	-2.82
Reliance	2.24	TCS	-1.73
L&T	2.18	ITC	-1.25

“Investor sentiment remained supported by a favourable election outcome in West Bengal and a better-than-expected Q4 earnings, helping markets look past Middle East-related concerns.

“However, intermittent profit booking persisted amid uncertainty surrounding the US ‘Project Freedom’ initiative to reopen the Strait of Hormuz,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

Rupee at all-time low of 95.23 against US dollar

Rupee fell 39 paise to close at an all-time low of 95.23 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, as the ongoing Middle East tensions are causing volatility in global markets, keeping oil prices high and raising fears of inflation and economic slowdown.

Forex traders said Brent oil, hovering near \$110 per barrel, is maintaining pressure on oil-importing economies like India. Moreover, factors such as unabated foreign capital outflows amid rising geopolitical uncertainties dented investor sentiments further.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.95 against the US dollar, then lost ground and finally settled for the day at 95.23 (provisional), registering a fall of 39 paise over its previous close. On Thursday, the rupee had settled at 94.84 against the American currency. Stock exchanges and currency markets were closed on Friday on account of Maharashtra Day.

“The Indian rupee has hit a record low as the dollar recovered and crude oil prices held firm. This ongoing surge in oil prices, combined with foreign fund outflows, is putting a visible strain on India’s trade balance and

Date	Rate (₹/USD)	Change
Apr 24	94.16	(-15p)
Apr 27	94.15	(+1p)
Apr 28	94.68	(-53p)
Apr 29	94.88	(-20p)
Apr 30	94.84	(+4p)
May 4	95.23*	(-39p)

*Provisional (Inverted Scale)

broader economy. “Persistent dollar demand is expected to keep the pressure on the rupee in the short term, driving the USD/INR higher toward the 95.35 and 95.70 levels,” said Dilip Parmar, Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 98.26, up 0.11 per cent. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 1.37 per cent at \$109.65 per barrel in futures trade. Investors’ focus was on counting of votes for the West Bengal state elections, IFA Global said in a research note, adding, “a BJP victory would be positive for domestic assets.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | MAY 5, 2026

BUSINESS13

Coal gasification: Catalysing India’s chemical industry growth and achieving Aatmanirbharta

India has a growing chemical industry that contributes to around 7% of the country’s GDP. The industry’s growth is heavily fuelled by the increasing domestic demand. With the industry producing more than 80,000 chemical products, it significantly contributes to agriculture, pharmaceuticals, textiles, packaging, and construction. Despite being one of the highest global consumers, India’s chemicals trade deficit at more than US\$ 30 billion, underscores the high dependence on imported feed-stock and specialty chemicals, particularly from China. The West Asia geopolitical crisis has further aggravated the situation, calling for India to rethink its strategy.

Coal has traditionally been used for power generation with coal contributing almost 70% of India’s electricity generation despite aggressive renewable expansion. Studies by NITI Aayog, Chintan Research Foundation and others indicate that coal will continue to provide base load power at least till 2050s, beyond which coal’s use may decline. Use of coal is essential to ensure India’s energy security and derive value from a commodity, which is in abundance in India, estimating at nearly 400 billion tonnes, among the largest globally. Coal could be gasified to produce gas for power generation, hydrogen, and chemicals like methanol, olefins, dimethyl ether (DME), and ammonia, among others, to reduce India’s import vulnerability as well as secure the raw materials used to make these products.

What is coal gasification?

Coal gasification technology involves the process of converting coal to syngas, which

is a mixture of carbon monoxide, hydrogen, carbon dioxide and other minor constituents like methane and water vapour. This is done by partial oxidation of coal at high temperature and pressure.

Driving supply-chain resilience: Reducing import dependence

The success of coal to chemicals in China shows that coal can be used for both gasification and liquefaction to produce chemicals. China started focusing on modern gasification

technology in the 2000s, using its locally available coal, to produce methanol, urea, DME, among others. Methanol to Olefins (MTO) technology was at the centre of this transition. Olefins, particularly ethylene, propylene, and butadiene, are the building blocks for the petrochemical industry. Not only was China’s import dependence reduced, but coal’s use also increased its domestic demand.

Methanol plays a critical role in the production of Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs), compounds essential for producing medicines. With India importing 70% of its APIs, methanol production using local coal could

help India strengthen its supply chain resilience for APIs to support generic medicine production, the largest in the world.

The DME obtained through coal gasification can be blended with LPG, thus reducing India’s import dependence.

Hydrogen produced from syngas, integrated with carbon capture, can be combined with nitrogen to produce ammonia and urea — a proven pathway being used in China — to reduce our imports.

Syngas can also be used in gas-based

tries. This will help boost the local economy and address the issue of job losses due to the shift away from coal used for thermal generation. In sum, coal gasification can facilitate a just transition for the mining communities affected by mine closures.

Pathway for India

Understanding the potential, the Indian Government launched the National Coal Gasification Mission in 2020 with the target of achieving 100 MT of coal gasification by 2030. Despite the potential, coal gasification in India has seen limited progress, constrained by technological and economic challenges. The time is ripe now for the central Government to renew its focus by providing infrastructure status to the sector, which can enable long-term coal linkages through transparent auctions, streamline approvals, and attract affordable capital. Furthermore, custom duty waivers and viability gap funding for early adopters will help in ensuring project viability. The state Governments can facilitate the speeding up of land acquisition, water allocation and recycling, environmental clearances, compliance approvals, and specialised electricity tariffs for the integrated coal gasification and chemicals clusters, to enable economies of scale and value-chain optimisation.

The transition to coal gasification should be considered a strategic necessity for India and not an economic burden, as this would help reduce India’s vulnerability, strengthening supply chain resilience and achieving Aatmanirbharta.

The coal to chemical industry sector can be established in a phased manner, not by a binary of replacing oil and gas, but in a complementary fashion to produce chemicals. Over time, the phased shift can make coal gasification the major source for generating chemical products.

Shagun Mamgain is a Research Consultant and Dr Debajit Palit is the Centre Head at Centre for Climate Change & Energy Transition in Chintan Research Foundation. Views expressed are personal

No Government financial support planned for fuel retailers’ petrol, diesel, ATF losses

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government has no plans to extend financial support to state-owned fuel retailers for the losses they are incurring on selling petrol, diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) below cost, an official said on Monday.

Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) are incurring substantial losses on sale of petrol and diesel after they extended a four-year freeze on revision in retail rates despite input crude oil prices shooting up since the start of West Asia conflict over two months back. They have also, for the first time in more than two decades, begun posting losses on jet fuel (ATF) since last month, as they

passed on only a part of the desired increase in prices needed to bring rates at par with cost.

“There is no proposal before the Government to support oil marketing companies (for their losses),” said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the

Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

While ATF prices for domestic airlines last month increased by 25 per cent — a fourth of the desired increase — there was no change in rates this month, even though the prices for foreign airlines

were hiked by over 5 per cent. Similarly, despite under-recoveries of ₹25-28 a litre, there has been no increase in petrol and diesel prices.

Domestic LPG prices were hiked by ₹60 per 14.2-kg cylinder on March 7, but that was not enough to cover all the increased cost, and oil companies are booking under-recoveries or losses. The Government has, in the past, covered for the under-recoveries on LPG through budgetary subsidy support.

Sharma said there is no increase in retail prices of petrol and diesel, as well as domestic LPG, even though supplies have been disrupted due to the war in West Asia. Only rates of bulk or industrial diesel, as also commercial LPG — the one used by hotels and restaurants — have been increased.

Fertiliser subsidy bill set to overshoot budget estimate amid West Asia crisis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government’s fertiliser subsidy bill for the 2026-27 fiscal is expected to exceed the budgetary allocation of ₹1.71 lakh crore, with rising costs of imported urea and other fertilisers driven by the ongoing West Asia crisis, a senior ministry official said on Monday.

“We know that the costs have risen. Cost of both urea and other fertilisers showing an upward trend... There will surely be an increase, but as of now, cannot say,” Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary in the Department of Fertilisers, said at an inter-ministerial briefing on developments in West Asia. Despite the supply chain disruptions triggered by the West Asia crisis, Sharma said fertiliser availability remains “strong and stable” for the kharif 2026 season.

Domestic production for March-April stood at 67.76 lakh tonnes - comprising

urea (40.72 lakh tonnes), Di ammonium Phosphate (5.39 lakh tonnes), NPK (13.65 lakh tonnes) and SSP (8 lakh tonnes) — supplemented by imports of 17 lakh tonnes. The imports were managed through coordinated efforts involving the ministries of ports and external affairs. For May, the department has set a domestic production target of 22 lakh tonnes of urea, 4 lakh tonnes of DAP and 8 lakh tonnes of NPK. Some urea plants that had temporarily shut down are set to resume operations, with gas supply already secured, she said.

A global tender for urea imports has been processed, with supplies expected in May-June. A separate global tender for 19 lakh tonnes of NPK fertilisers has also been floated to meet peak demand.

The Department of Agriculture has assessed the fertiliser requirement for kharif 2026 at 390.54 lakh tonnes. Against this, states have already stocked 195.71 lakh tonnes — nearly 50 per cent of the requirement — reflecting what officials described as “improved planning and advanced stocking”.

State-wise demand has been mapped based on the agriculture ministry’s assessment, with stocking and advance planning already undertaken. Beyond central-level stocking, redistribution within districts remains the responsibility of state Governments.

“We are having regular meetings with states. As the season approaches, a 24x7 contingency cell will be set up to tackle redistribution issues,” Sharma said.

Asia and Pacific region must build shared resilience: ADB President

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ Samarkand (Uzbekistan)

Asian Development Bank (ADB) President Masato Kanda on Monday urged Asia and the Pacific region to ‘act together to develop together’ through stronger cross-border connections that drive resilience and inclusive growth.

“The decisions we make at this new crossroads will secure the future for the next generation,” Kanda said at the inaugural session

of ADB’s 59th Annual Meeting here.

“In this fragmented world, traditional and isolated development responses will fail. To survive and thrive in this new era, we must build deeply connected and resilient systems,” he said.

He underscored how shocks today travel rapidly across borders — through energy markets, supply chains, and digital networks — hitting communities that are least able to absorb them.

Addressing these challenges

requires coordinated regional solutions that go beyond national boundaries, he said.

ADB is responding by scaling up investments and accelerating reforms that enable countries to integrate infrastructure, markets, and institutions across Asia and the Pacific. Last year, the bank provided \$29.3 billion in financial support to the region, while implementing reforms that enable it to deliver assistance more quickly and at scale.

On Sunday, ADB launched a \$70-billion programme to build regional systems that will strengthen shared security and resilience in Asia and the Pacific.

This includes a \$50-billion initiative to build a pan-Asia power grid, which aims to integrate renewable energy across borders, enhance energy security, and lower emissions; and a \$20-billion initiative designed to expand cross-border digital connectivity and close the region’s digital divide.

FTA: India, Canada begin next round talks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India and Canada on Monday started second round of negotiations for a free trade agreement aimed at boosting two-way commerce and investments, an official said.

The pact is officially known as the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) and negotiations will cover trade in goods, services, and other mutually agreed policy areas.

“The five-day talks started on May 4 here,” the official

important as the two sides have fixed a target to increase the bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030. It stood at \$8.66 billion in 2024-25 (\$4.22 billion exports and \$4.44 billion imports).

Canada represents a market of 41.65 million people (2025) and a GDP of \$2.34 trillion at purchasing power parity.

Key exports from India to Canada include pharmaceuticals, iron and steel, seafood, cotton garments, electronic goods and chemicals, among others. Key imports include

said. The first round was held in March.

This round is important as Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will visit Canada by end of this month to give an impetus to the negotiations.

The negotiations mark the resumption of talks, as the two countries had earlier engaged in a similar exercise, but Canada paused it in 2023. Now, they decided to resume talks from the beginning as a lot has changed on the global trade front during these two years. The negotiations are

pulses, pearls and semi-precious stones, coal, fertiliser, paper and petroleum crude.

India’s main services sector exports include telecommunications, computer and information services, and other business services.

Canada is also home to over 425,000 Indian students and a strong Indian community.

Joint Secretary in the Department of Commerce, Brij Mohan Mishra, is the chief negotiator from the Indian side. Bruce Christie is Canada’s chief negotiator.

PROSPECT

Jindal Stainless reports 41% rise in Q4 profit to ₹834 cr



Jindal Stainless on Monday posted over 41 per cent growth in consolidated net profit to ₹834.21 crore during the quarter ended March 31, driven by higher revenues. The company had reported a net profit of ₹589.96 crore in the year-ago period, according to an exchange filing. During the fourth quarter, the company's total income rose to ₹11,427.91 crore from ₹10,292.27 crore in the January-March period of the preceding 2024-25 financial year. For the entire FY26, the company's net profit jumped to ₹3,184 crore from ₹2,499.72 crore in the year ago. Total income rose to ₹43,306.14 crore during the fiscal ended March 2026, from ₹39,603.06 crore in 2024-25 financial year.

Exide Industries Q4 PAT up 15 per cent at ₹216.73 crores

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Battery maker Exide Industries Ltd on Monday reported a 15 per cent growth in consolidated profit after tax at ₹216.73 crore in the fourth quarter ended March 31, 2026, on the back of strong growth across key businesses. The company had posted a consolidated profit after tax (PAT) of ₹187.91 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal, Exide Industries Ltd said in a regulatory filing.

Consolidated revenue from operations in the fourth quarter stood at ₹4,735.13 crore as against ₹4,335.42 crore in the year-ago period, it added. Total expenses in the fourth quarter were higher at Rs 4,411.63 crore as compared to ₹4,089.98 crore in the same period a year ago, the company said.

For the fiscal year ending March 31, 2026, consolidated profit after tax (PAT) was at ₹859.92 crore as against ₹800.5 crore in the previous year.

Consolidated revenue from operations in FY26 stood at ₹17,995.35 crore as compared



to ₹17,237.85 crore in FY25.

Commenting on the performance, Exide Industries MD & CEO, Avik Roy, said, "Q4 FY26 built on the gains observed in Q3 — GST rationalisation continued to boost end-customer demand across the automotive sector, supported by strong replacement market and energy storage demand."

The company achieved over 25 per cent growth in the auto OEM business.

Inverters and solar businesses showed robust growth of "mid-to-high teens", while auto replacement and infrastructure businesses, excluding telecom, also showed double-digit growth, he added.

Roy noted that macroeconomic conditions in India remained favourable with low inflation, lower Repo rates and positive rural and urban

Gadkari reviews major highway corridor projects

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari on Monday reviewed the proposed high-speed corridors, high-density corridors and other important National Highway corridors in Maharashtra, according to an official statement.

During the review meeting in New Delhi, Gadkari discussed several key highway development projects including six-laning of the Nagpur-Bhandara section, four-laning of the Taloda-Burhanpur section, the Durg-Gadchiroli-Manchari corridor, the Gadchiroli-Kanker (Raipur-Vizag) corridor, and the Gwalior-Nagpur corridor among others, according to the statement. The review meeting also included discus-



sions on nine State BOT (Build-Operate-Transfer) projects covering a total length of 527 km on National Highway stretches in Maharashtra.

These projects include Shirur-Ahilyanagar (4-lane), Ahilyanagar-Wadala (4-lane), Wadala-Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar (4-lane), Chhatrapati Sambhaji nagar-Jalna (4-lane),

Jalna-Watur (4-lane), Nanded-Narsi-Deglur (4-lane & 2-lane), Jam-Warora (4-lane), Warora-Chandrapur-Bamni (4-lane), and Malkapur-Chikhli (2-lane) corridors. The statement said the review focused on accelerating project planning and execution to strengthen road connectivity and support economic development in the region.

BHEL shares jump 7% after March quarter earnings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Shares of BHEL on Monday surged 7 per cent after the firm reported a more than 2.5 times jump in consolidated net profit in the quarter ended March 2026.

The company's stock jumped 6.97 per cent to settle at ₹376.95 on the BSE. Intra-day, it soared 13.20 per cent to ₹398.95 — the 52-week high level.

At the NSE, the stock surged 6.99 per cent to settle at ₹377.05.

The company's market valuation climbed ₹8,548.47 crore to ₹1,31,256.38 crore.

BHEL on Monday reported a more than 2.5 times jump in consolidated net profit to ₹1,290.47 crore for the quarter ended March 2026, supported by growth in revenues mainly from the power segment.

It had reported a net profit of ₹504.45 crore in the same period a year ago, the company said in an exchange filing.

During the fourth quarter, its total income surged to ₹12,553.50 crore



from ₹9,142.64 crore in the January-March period of the preceding 2024-25 financial year.

The revenue from the power segment during the quarter was at ₹9,509.85 crore, up from ₹6,192.41 crore in January-March FY25.

For the entire FY26, the company's net profit jumped to ₹1,600.26 crore from ₹533.90 crore in the year ago.

Total income rose to ₹34,589.83 crore during the fiscal ended March 2026, from ₹28,804.79 crore in the 2024-25 financial year.

BHEL is India's largest engineering and manufacturing enterprise in the energy and infrastructure sectors.

Ambuja Cements Q4 profit jumps 37.4 pc to ₹1,857.43 cr

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

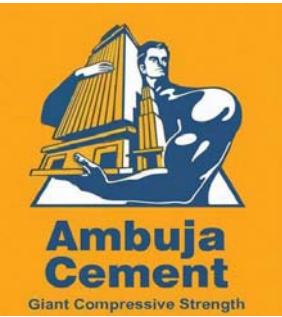
The Adani Group firm Ambuja Cements Ltd on Monday reported a 37.43 per cent increase in its profit after tax to ₹1,857.43 crore in the March quarter of 2025-26 compared to the year-ago period.

It had reported a profit after tax (PAT) of ₹1,351.46 crore in the January-March quarter of the last fiscal, according to a regulatory filing from Ambuja Cements Ltd (ACL).

ACL's consolidated revenue from operations was at ₹10,891.68 crore, up 10 per cent in the March quarter of FY26 compared to ₹9,894.41 crore in the corresponding period last fiscal.

Total expenses were at ₹10,525.09 crore, up 19.3 per cent in Q4 of FY26.

Its revenue from cement was at ₹10,417.69 crore, up 8.6 per cent during the quarter. Ready Mix Concrete contributed ₹581.95 crore, up 36.54 per cent over the same



period of FY25.

Total consolidated sales volume of ACL, the second-largest cement manufacturer of the country, stood at 19.9 million tonnes (MT) during the quarter, up 9.34 per cent. In the March quarter, the Adani Group firm, which has in past made acquisitions to expand its operating capacity, reported "highest ever quarterly revenue" along with "highest ever sales volume".

Its total consolidated income, which includes other income as well, was up 5.64 per cent to ₹11,149.36 crore. It was at ₹10,553.81 crore in the corresponding

March quarter of FY25.

Commenting on the results, ACL Whole Time Director & CEO Vinod Bahety said, "Volumes grew well ahead of the industry, followed by improved realisations driven by a higher share of trade & premium products, and better utilisation of the existing assets."

The consolidated results of Ambuja Cements include the financial performance of its step-down firm ACC Ltd, in which it owns around 51 per cent stake along with Orient Cements and others.

On a standalone basis, which includes only ACL's performance, in the March quarter, its revenue from operations was up 5.51 per cent to ₹6,972.21 crore, and its PAT was up two-fold to ₹1,643.66 crore.

In the entire FY26, ACL reported a profit of Rs 5,637.08 crore, up 6.47 per cent. Total consolidated income rose 5.64 per cent to ₹41,490.02 crore during the financial year ended March 2026.

UPI achieves 22.35 bn transactions in April: DFS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

About 22.35 billion transactions were carried out through the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) in April, Department of Financial Services said on Monday. In volume terms, UPI transactions grew 25 per cent in April 2026 over the April 2025 when it was 17.89 billion.

The UPI transactions had touched a record high of 22.64 billion in volume terms in March, up from 20.39 billion recorded in February. "UPI achieves 22.35 Bn transaction count in April'26i," Department of Financial Services said in a post on X.

UPI combines the ease of use with strong security while following the RBI's two-factor authentication rule. This first factor is the mobile number linked to the user's bank and the second is the UPI PIN, making transactions quick



and safe from unauthorised access.

Today, UPI accounts for about 85 per cent of all digital transactions in India. Its impact goes beyond national borders, powering nearly 50 per cent of global real-time digital payments. UPI is already live in eight countries, including the UAE, Singapore, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, France, Mauritius, and Qatar. This allows Indians travelling or living there to pay seamlessly without the usual hassles of foreign transactions.

NPCI, an initiative of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Indian Banks' Association, is an umbrella organisation for operating retail payments and settlement systems in India (IBA),

DAILY SUDOKU

6		7			5			1
	8	1	6		7			
3				4				
	9		2			7		
			2	7		4	1	
		4				6		9
				7				8
			1		9	5	7	
1			5			2		9

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (4.05.26)								
6	3	2	7	1	8	4	9	5
1	4	8	9	3	5	2	6	7
5	9	7	6	4	2	1	8	3
9	8	5	3	6	4	7	2	1
7	6	1	2	5	9	3	4	8
3	2	4	1	8	7	6	5	9
2	5	3	8	7	6	9	1	4
4	1	6	5	9	3	8	7	2
8	7	9	4	2	1	5	3	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD TUESDAY | MAY 5, 2026

1	2		3	4		5		6	7		8
			9								
10								11			
					12						
13		14							15		16
17							18				
						19					
20	21								22		23
24						25					
				26							
27									28		
					29						
30										31	

ACROSS

- The greatest way to eat? (5)
- Glide smoothly yet very noisily in a boat (5)
- It's on the wing (7)
- Next to synthetic fur, it's a natural product (5)
- Runs out, as mother does at teatime! (5)
- Was slow to get a republican in court (5)
- Thought highly of, though always in the red (7)
- Aged figures with plenty of energy (3)
- Soon admits ignorance of authorship (4)
- A scale used somewhere on the Continent (6)
- Roman who, having got in, went out to work at a trade! (5)
- Finds an unfulfilled desire irritating? (6)
- Enough beef for eleven? (4)
- Quite definitely it's said to be cast (3)
- Spanish sportsman, a cad at heart (7)
- Like Herb, he has his roots in the soil (5)
- A wooden one's not for winning (5)
- Long neglected duty about the first of September (5)
- At the end of winter, wild cats spread out (7)
- James, the father of David? (5)
- Sort of drum for a catchy rhythm? (5)

DOWN

- Get tough on difficult points (6)
- Girl bowled over? (6)
- Location of tip-up seats? (3)
- Can it keep one's chest a bit warm in bed? (5)
- In a silly, sentimental yet absorbing way? (7)
- It's tied to the idea of speed (4)
- Favourable figures relating to acid (6)
- Battery units (5)
- Frantic weaving of braid (5)
- There's something gripping about love, say (5)
- A name I had for being good (5)
- Something to read (5)
- Smith's property in the block (5)
- What a sinner may do with a letter from Penzance (7)
- Drink it up very quietly, there's some left! (6)
- Planet starting satisfactorily to rotate (6)
- Who? (6)
- Potable paint, possibly? (5)
- An extra big-hearted employer? (4)
- Sideshow man? (3)
- Gone through (5)
- Squaremeal (6)
- Tiger lily (5)
- Man-date (5)
- Pistol (5)
- Desolate (5)
- Son-net (5)
- Oatmeal (5)
- Ex-acts (5)
- Thee (5)
- Fortune (5)
- Put out (5)
- Viv's age (5)
- Discus! (5)
- Sheer (5)
- Ahead (5)
- Has-been (5)
- Opt-i-mum (5)
- Lo-tto (5)
- Leave (5)
- Get-a-t-able (5)
- Ag-at-it (5)
- Clai-me-d (5)
- Catches on (5)
- Laugh (5)
- Thin-g (5)
- Ring-let (5)
- Concern (5)
- Thre-e (5)
- Prior (5)
- To-sil-les (5)
- B-and-it (5)
- Posted (5)
- Ran-sack (5)
- 24, Gone through (5)
- 26, Squaremeal (6)
- 28, Tiger lily (5)
- 29, Man-date (5)
- 30, Pistol (5)
- 32, Desolate (5)
- 33, Son-net (5)
- 34, Oatmeal (5)
- 38, Ex-acts (5)
- 40, Thee (5)

SOLUTION (4.05.26)

- ACROSS
- Clai-me-d
 - Catches on
 - Laugh
 - Thin-g
 - Ring-let
 - Concern
 - Thre-e
 - Prior
 - To-sil-les
 - B-and-it
 - Posted
 - Ran-sack

DOWN

- Fortune
- Put out
- Viv's age
- Discus!
- Sheer
- Ahead
- Has-been
- Opt-i-mum
- Lo-tto
- Leave
- Get-a-t-able
- Ag-at-it

- 24, Gone through
- 26, Squaremeal
- 28, Tiger lily
- 29, Man-date
- 30, Pistol
- 32, Desolate
- 33, Son-net
- 34, Oatmeal
- 38, Ex-acts
- 40, Thee

Supply of dry-fuel to power sector by Coal India arm SECL rises 8.2% to 12.49 MT in April

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Coal India arm South Eastern Coalfields Ltd (SECL) on Monday said coal supply to the power sector jumped 8.2 per cent to 12.49 million tonnes (MT) during April.

Coal despatch by SECL stood at 11.54 MT in April last year.

The increase underscores SECL's sustained emphasis on prioritising coal supply to the power sector, aligning with directives from the coal ministry.

This growth reflects the miniratna company's ongoing efforts to bolster



fuel availability amid rising power demand, ensuring steady operations for thermal plants.

SECL, a leading coal producer with major operations in the Korba coalfields of Chhattisgarh and across parts of Central India, has been ramping up production and logistics to meet national energy needs.

According to the company's CMD Harish Duhan, SECL remains committed to sustaining this momentum and ensuring reliable coal availability to meet the country's power demand.

The company said that SECL has made a strong start to 2026-27, with coal production at 15.31 MT in April 2026, registering a growth of 9.25 per cent over the corresponding period last year.

During the same period, overburden removal stood at 33.10 million cubic metres (MCuM), up by 4.49 per cent, while coal offtake reached 15.85 MT, reflecting a growth

of 4.03 per cent.

This performance has been enabled by improved land availability in key mega projects in the Korba region during the previous financial year, coupled with focused monitoring of critical operations.

Both opencast and underground segments have contributed positively, supported by enhanced operational efficiency.

SECL remains focused on maintaining production momentum and ensuring a reliable coal supply to the power sector, particularly in the context of evolving demand conditions.

Air India SATS inks pact to fast-track Samsung Data Systems shipments

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Gateway and cargo service operator Air India SATS Airport Services (AISATS) has signed an agreement with Samsung Data Systems India to fast-track shipments of the latter's products from the multi-modal cargo hub at the Noida International Airport.

Samsung has a manufacturing facility at Noida in Uttar Pradesh, one of the world's largest mobile manufacturing clusters, producing smartphones, tablets, laptops, and other devices.

This partnership will significantly enhance cargo efficiency, providing a streamlined export pathway for high-value electronics shipments, further strengthening India's position as a leading



electronics exporter with Samsung SDS playing a pivotal role in logistics digital transformation, AISATS said. The strategic proximity to Samsung's manufacturing unit will enable faster cargo throughput, reduced transit time, and improved access to export markets, driving profitability, it said.

The cargo hub at Noida airport is spread across 87 acres and designed as an integrated logistics platform, with a 30-acre Integrated Cargo Terminal (ICT) and a

57-acre Integrated Warehousing and Logistics Zone to cater to various sectors, including pharmaceuticals, electronics, engineering goods, and e-commerce. The facility has an annual handling capacity of approximately 255,000 metric tonnes of cargo in phase 1 at its ICT.

"India's role as a global manufacturing hub, particularly in electronics, requires logistics infrastructure that is agile, reliable, and at par with international standards. Our partnership with Samsung SDS is a significant step in enabling high-value, time-sensitive cargo to move seamlessly through a globally benchmarked cargo ecosystem," said Ramanathan Rajamani, CEO, AISATS.

NSE launches Electronic Gold Receipts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) on Monday launched Electronic Gold Receipts (EGRs) as a new segment, in a bid to create a more transparent and efficient price discovery of the yellow metal.

The move is expected to bridge the age-old gap between physical gold and the financial markets by offering a regulated, secure, and technologically-advanced platform for trading in the precious commodity, the exchange said in a statement. EGRs are dematerialised securities representing ownership of physical gold, which is securely stored in Sebi-accredited vaults and held electronically through depositories.

BRIEFLY

Mendy injured in Madrid's win over Espanyol



Defender Ferland Mendy was injured 10 minutes into Real Madrid's 2-0 win over Espanyol in the Spanish league on Sunday. The latest setback could end any hopes of making France's squad for the World Cup.

The 30-year-old Mendy, who has suffered a series of injuries this season, was a member of the French squad at the 2024 European Championship but hasn't been called up since then.

Mendy has played only nine matches with Real Madrid this season.

He got hurt on Sunday while sprinting to the ball, and went down with an apparent right leg muscle injury.

Madrid did not immediately release details on the severity of the injury.

Stewart Cink adds another PGA TOUR Champions



Stewart Cink pulled away with consecutive birdies early on the back nine Sunday that stretched his lead to four shots, and he closed with a 3-under 69 for a three-shot victory in the Regions Tradition for his second major this year on the PGA Tour Champions.

Cink, who won the Senior PGA Championship two weeks ago in Florida, became the second player in two years to capture the first two majors on the 50-and-older circuit.

Angel Cabrera won the Senior PGA and the Tradition last year in consecutive weeks.

"This weekend was a little scrappy," Cink said. "I'm really proud I was able to stay out front."

He was staked to a three-shot lead going into the final round at Greystone Golf & Country Club, and Colin Montgomerie got within two shots of them heading to the back nine.

The 52-year-old Cink responded with birdies on the 11th and 12th holes to build a four-shot lead, and Montgomerie failed to make birdie over his final 13 holes to shoot 71 and finish alone in third.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Major Indevir Singh S/o Colonel Hamam Singh Chandhoke have lost the following documents Demand cum Allotment Letter, Possession Letter, NOC for Electricity connection, water connection Pertaining to my Flat to (DDA Flat) No. B-2E Vatikha Apartments, G-8 area Rajouri Garden Mayapuri New Delhi-110064. If the above Documents are found Contact me at Mob 9818747027/Above Address.

PUBLIC NOTICE

TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN

This is to inform all concerned that effective from 17SEPT2025 the Registered Office address of **M/s J.P. Engineers Private Limited** (CIN: U51504DL2014PTC266624) is: **M/s J.P. Engineers Private Limited K-73-A, R/S Basement, Shop No. 3, Kalkaji, South Delhi, New Delhi – 110019, India**

All clients, associates, and concerned parties are hereby requested to note the change and contact the company at the above-mentioned address for all future correspondence.

For any queries or communication, please Contact: 9872713780 Email: contact@jpenginers.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Mr. Rishabh Kapoor, Mr. Pradeep Kapoor and Mrs. Geeta Kapoor (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgagees/Borrowers), are purchasing Entire First Floor without roof rights, built on Property No. J-6/36, addressing 160 Sq. Yds., situated in the area of village Tatarpur and the colony Known as Rajouri Garden, New Delhi-110028 (hereinafter referred to as the said property) from Mrs. Asha Arora, who became the owner of the said property vide Sale Deed dated 19.06.2024, regd. as Doc. No. 2024/25/16839, in Book No. 1, Vol. No. 11815, on pages 95-112, on 21.06.2024 read with Partition Deed dated 09.12.2025, regd. as Doc. No. 2025/25/34618, Book No. 1, Vol. No. 16752, Page Nos. 77 to 95, on 11.12.2025. The Borrowers will create mortgage in respect of the said property in favour of our clients Indusind Bank Ltd., 12th Floor, Hyatt Regency, Bhikaji Cama Place, Delhi. The other original title deeds i.e. Conveyance Deed dated 25.01.1957 (Doc. No. 258), Sale Deed dated 24.08.1959 (Doc. No. 3369), Sale Deed dated 08.04.1964 (Doc. No.1456) & Supplementary Deed dated 21.04.1964 (Doc. No. 1594) are in possession of the other owner of the property and hence cannot be verified. Any person, body, individual, institution having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property by way of sale, exchange, lease, lien, mortgage, charge, encumbrance, gift, trust, easement, maintenance, inheritance, testamentary deposit or otherwise or having in their custody any title documents pertaining to the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support there of, failing which all the claim, of such person shall be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. Any objections raised after the completion of the 07 days shall not be binding upon the said property or my client.

Adv. Simran Bajaj, 100,1st Floor, Okhla phase-III New Delhi-110020; Phone:+91 114974545/99

Hardie leads Peshawar to first PSL cricket title



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Lahore

Aaron Hardie's brilliant all-round performance led Peshawar Zalmi to its first Pakistan Super League cricket title since 2017 with a five-wicket win over newcomer Hyderabad Kingsmen in the final.

Hardie grabbed 4-27 to bowl out Hyderabad for a below-par 129 all out in 18 overs with Saim Ayub (54) scoring a fighting half century. Hardie then hit a fluent 56 not out off 39 balls and anchored Peshawar to 130-5 in 15.2 overs in front of a packed crowd at Gaddafi Stadium.

"It's a very big achievement for me, for Peshawar Zalmi and all the fans," said Peshawar captain Babar Azam after winning his first PSL title as skipper. "Throughout the tournament we've performed really well as a team and every player executed the plans they were given in batting, bowling, and field-

ing. Our plan was to go match by match."

Peshawar, which won the toss and chose to chase, had slumped to 40-4 inside the first five overs after losing tournament top run-scorer Babar for a golden duck while Mohammad Haris, Kusal Mendis and Michael Bracewell also fell for single-digit scores.

But Hardie, who smashed nine fours, then combined in a match-winning stand of 85 runs with Abdul Samad (48), who missed out on his half century before holing out in the deep when Peshawar needed only five runs for victory. "It was just a great game of cricket," Hardie said. "Kingsmen came out of the blocks really hard. They've certainly had a lot of momentum from the last couple of games and they carried that in, but I'm really proud of the way the boys were able to fight back."

Peshawar was favorite for the title after it lost only one

game in the tournament with Babar, who scored two centuries, equaling Fakhar Zaman's PSL record of 588 runs in one edition of the tournament.

Hyderabad had a productive power play of 69-2 despite Hardie having captain Marnus Labuschagne (20) caught behind of a rising delivery and Maaz Sadaqat's early aggression was cut short to just 11 runs when he half-heartedly pulled pace bowler Mohammad Basit to deep backward square leg in the first over.

However, Hyderabad lost momentum and crashed to 73-6 in the space of nine balls after the power play for just two runs.

The slide began when Usman Khan, coming into the final with half centuries in the last three successive games, was trapped leg before wicket by the tournament's leading wicket-taker Sufyan Moqim (1-23).



Inter Milan seals Italian league soccer title

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Milan

Inter Milan sealed the Italian league soccer title with a 2-0 victory over visiting Parma.

Inter, which needed only a draw to secure the trophy, moved an unassailable 12 points clear of 2025 champion Napoli with three rounds remaining. It's Inter's 21st Serie A title, trailing only the record 36 held by Juventus.

Marcus Thuram scored just before the break with an angled shot placed just beyond the reach of Parma goalkeeper Zion Suzuki. Then 37-year-old Henrikh Mkhitaryan added another in the 80th after taking a pass from Serie A scoring leader Lautaro Martinez, who came off the bench to mark his return from an injury layoff.

Thuram was born in Parma while his father, Lilian Thuram, played there.

For Cristian Chivu, Inter's first-year coach, the trophy was secured against the club he coached last season —

having helped Parma avoid relegation. Chivu, who was hired to replace the departed Simone Inzaghi nearly a year ago, played on the Inter team that won a treble under Jose Mourinho in 2010.

In the running for two trophies this season, Inter will face Lazio in the Italian Cup final in 10 days.

The domestic success has come in sharp contrast to Inter's ouster from this season's Champions League playoffs by tiny Norwegian club Bodø/Glimt. Last season, Inter was routed 5-0 by Paris Saint-Germain in the Champions League final.

Still, it's an improvement from last season's Serie A when Inter finished one point behind Napoli.

AC Milan and Juventus at risk: While Inter was celebrating, AC Milan and Juventus were at risk of losing their Champions League places. Milan was reduced to 10 men and beaten 2-0 at Sassuolo for its

fourth loss in seven matches. Then Juventus drew 1-1 with relegated Hellas Verona.

Third-placed Milan was left only two points ahead of fourth-placed Juventus, which is just three points ahead of fifth-placed Como, which is trying to get into the top four and secure a Champions League spot.

Three rounds remain in the Italian league. Milan has scored only one goal in its last five matches. Christian Pulisic, who came on in the second half, extended his goalless streak to a career-high 17 league matches.

Vlahovic equalizes for Juventus: Juventus also dropped points at home against Verona but extended its unbeaten run to nine matches. Kieron Bowie put Verona ahead after intercepting a pass from Juventus defender Gleison Bremer then Dusan Vlahovic equalized for Juventus with a free kick around Verona's wall for his first goal since October.

Max Verstappen takes 5th at Miami but still wants improvements to his car

ALANIS THAMESAP ■ Miami Gardens (Florida)

Max Verstappen was feeling a bit more comfortable in his car at the Miami Grand Prix, but the four-time Formula 1 champion still believes Red Bull has improvements to make.

After testing out Red Bull's upgrades made during a five-week break in the F1 schedule, Verstappen had his best result of the season on Sunday, finishing fifth despite spinning from second on the opening lap.

Verstappen has been a

vocal critic of the current car regulations, even going as far as saying he's considering leaving the sport. He left Miami only slightly happier with the car.

"I mean, my car drives a bit better," said Verstappen, who qualified a season-best second for the race at Miami International Autodrome. "But what I said before about the regulations is the same... It's still not how I would like to see it."

Verstappen was part of a chaotic start to Sunday's race when he



always go Rally (racing)." Verstappen worked his way through the midfield back into third, even briefly taking the lead as others pitted. He attempted to make it a one-stop race, an approach that eventually cost him.

"After that (spin) I think the pace was not too bad on the medium (tires)," he said, "but as soon as I swapped to the hard compound (tires) it was just a lot more difficult. Now, after the race it's

easy to say of course, but I think that stint was just a bit too long."

Tough weekend for Ferrari: Leclerc settled for a sixth-place finish despite getting off to a strong start from third.

He was among the leaders throughout the race, but a costly move on the penultimate lap caused him to spin and hit the barriers. "The damage was signifi-

cant," Leclerc said afterward, adding: "I'm very disappointed with myself. It's all on me and it's not acceptable." Leclerc's teammate Lewis Hamilton said it was a disappointing weekend he qualified sixth and finished seventh. Hamilton's car was affected by an apparent collision with Franco Colapinto of Alpine at the start.

(AP)

NORTHERN RAILWAY	
TENDER NOTICE (Through e-tendering)	
Name of work with its location	Provision of fencing for location boxes under ADSTE/FDB section of Delhi division.
App. Cost of the work (₹)	Rs. 38,46,210.00/-
Bid Security (₹)	Rs. 76,900.00/-
Address of the office	Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer-C, Northern Railway, 3 rd Floor, Annex-1, DRM office, New Delhi-110055.
Date & Time for uploading the tender/closing of the tender	Tender uploading 04.05.2026 / closing date & time- 29.05.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.
Website particular & notice board/location where complete details of the tender can be seen etc.	See the Northern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in & Notice board at the S&T branch, 3 rd Floor, DRM office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055.
Tender No. 558-Sig-16-M-TENDER-1478 Dated: 04.05.2026 1483/2026	
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE	

NORTHERN RAILWAY			
INVITATION OF TENDERS THROUGH E-PROCUREMENT SYSTEM			
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for the supply of the following items:-			
S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Closing Date
1.	06261139	M.S. FLAT SIZE 50X6MM STANDARD LENGTH	22.05.2026
2.	06251002	PIG IRON FOR FOUNDRY PURPLE	25.05.2026
3.	09263050	GENTIAN BLUE ENAMEL FINISHING PAINT	28.05.2026
4.	77269020	RUNNING CONTRACT FOR METAL LINERS	20.05.2026
5.	77269061	RUNNING CONTRACT FOR HVN LINERS (T-8992)	29.05.2026
6.	02260081	HIGH VOLTAGE FUSE RATING 125A WITH FUSE	01.06.2026
7.	12260029A	EARTHING CABLE COMPLETE	08.06.2026
Note: 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.			
Tender Notice No.: 09/2026-2027 Dated: 04.05.2026 1482/2026			
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE			

11001/26/2627	GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT Lokaseva Bhavan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar – 751001
Phone: 0674-2392133 Website: https://dhe.odisha.gov.in Mail: sec3hed@gmail.com	
CORRIGENDUM & CLARIFICATION OF RFP NO.GCNE:02/2026 dt.21.04.2026	
Higher Education Department had invited RFP for 'CONSTRUCTION OF COMPLETE INFRASTRUCTURE FOR 18 NEWLY ESTABLISHED GOVERNMENT COLLEGES, ONE MDC UNDER RUSA, INFRASTRUCTURE FOR B.ED. COLLEGES, HOSTELS FOR 12 EXISTING GOVERNMENT HEIS, 20 HOSTELS FOR AIDED COLLEGES'	
The complete details of corrigendum & clarification are available at https://dhe.odisha.gov.in	
Sd/-	Special Secretary to Govt.,GCNE, HED
OIPR-11001/11001/1/2627/0005	

PUBLIC NOTICE

General public is hereby informed that Smt. BUSHRA TASNHEEM W/o Late Sh. LAIQUE AHMED KAMRAN, R/o A-6/38, SECTOR-18, ROHINI, DELHI-110089, has applied for transfer of ownership of Flat No. T-2/0704 (Customer ID No. KLH/00296/25-26), LAKE SIDE HEIGHTS, Sonapat, Haryana in her name claiming ownership as the legal heir of the deceased Late Sh. LAIQUE AHMED KAMRAN, as per documents dated 17-10-2025 the records of the company, i.e., MYS TDI INFRCORP (INDIA) LTD., having its office at Vandana Building, 11, Tolstoy Marg, New Delhi-110001. Any person having any objection for transfer of the said flat in favour of Smt. BUSHRA TASNHEEM W/o Late Sh. LAIQUE AHMED KAMRAN may send at the above noted office of company with supporting documents or through email customer.care@tdiinfrcorp.com within 15 days of the publication of this notice otherwise it shall be assumed that there are no objections to the proposed transfer of the said flat in his/her name. After that company shall not be liable for any claim whatsoever after 15 days.

TDI Infrcorp (India) Ltd.
Vandana Building, 11, Tolstoy Marg, New Delhi-110001
Phone No. 011-43111111
Manish Arora (Advocate) Supreme Court of India, Cn. No. 06, Block, Additional Building Complex Supreme Court, New Delhi-110001.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Deputy Chief Engineer Const.-II, Shivaji bridge, Northern Railway, New Delhi for and on behalf of the President of India invites open E-Tender for the following work. Tender closing date-**25.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.** Bidders will be able to submit their original/revised bids up to closing date and time only. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any manual offer received shall be ignored. Bidder should visit the www.ireps.gov.in website for all details including corrigendum etc.

Mode of Tender : E-Tender (Single Packet) (Open Tender)

Tender Notice No. : 148-W-Dy. CE-C-II-CSB Date: 04.05.2026

Full name of work : Maintenance and renovation of the office complex of DYCE/ C-II/CSB at Shivaji Bridge, New Delhi.

Approx. cost : Rs. 61,95,491/- (Rs. Sixty one lacs ninety five thousand four hundred ninety one only).

Bid security (Cash/BG) amount : Rs. 1,23,900/- (Rs. One lakh twenty three thousand nine hundred only)

Completion period : 12 (twelve) Months

Availability of tender document on Rly. website : Available on IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in. Tender detail and other instructions are as per NIT available on above mentioned IREPS site.

Tender availability on website : 04.05.2026

Tender closing date : 25.05.2026 upto 15.00 hours.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1486/2026

KEY CORP LIMITED					
CIN No..L65921UP1985PLC007547 Regd. Office:16/16-A, Civil Lines, Kanpur - 208001 Email: keycorpltd@gmail.com					
EXTRACT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULT FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31ST MARCH-2026					
		Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
Sl. No	Particulars	31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.12.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	11.62	177.29	(579.38)	512.00
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items#)	(961.65)	158.59	(597.20)	430.90
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items#)	(961.65)	158.59	(597.20)	430.90
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items#)	(961.61)	158.59	(597.20)	431.84
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(953.98)	167.27	(533.72)	463.58
6.	Equity Share Capital	600.00	600.00	600.00	600.00
7.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year	-	-	-	6189.56
8.	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - Basic & Diluted (in ₹)	(15.90)	2.79	(8.90)	7.73
Notes: 1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 & Regulation 52 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 as amended. The full format of the Quarterly & Year ended 31st March, 2026 Financial Results are available on the website. https://www.bseindia.com/stock-share-price/key-corp-ltd/keycorp/ / 507948 / financials-results-special/ of the Stock Exchange. 2. The above results have been reviewed by the Audit committee and approved by the Board of Directors of the company at its meeting held on 04.05.2026.					
Place: Kanpur Date: 04.05.2026		By Order of the Board (G.D. Maheshwari) Whole Time Director DIN 00235209			

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, hitherto known as NAITIK KHATRI ALIAS NATIK S/O DHARMENDER KHATRI R/O HOUSE NO. 390, NEAR M.C.D. SCHOOL, VILLAGE BANKNER, VTC NARELA, PO. DISTRICT NORTH WEST DELHI; DELHI-110040, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as NAITIK KHATRI.

I, Pratima Devi, W/o No. 15420153L HAV/ORA Santosh Kumar, Unit- Army Hospital R&R Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my name from Pratima Deveen to Pratima Devi, vide affidavit dated 04/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Kamala Devi W/o No. 07071998N HAV (Hony Nb Sub) Late Sri Niwas Tiwari, R/o Vill & PO- Asha Parari, Teh- Dumraon, Dist- Buxar, State-Bihar, PIN- 802135, declare that my correct name is Kamala Devi & Date of Birth is 05 Jan 1945, vide Affidavit No. 3910 dated 02 May 2026 before Notary public, Dumraon, Buxar, Bihar.

PD(1019)C I, Mithlesh W/o- No.15708683M Hav Pavan Kumar, R/o- Vill- Naya Bela, Post- Pachhayyan Gaon, Teh & Dist- Etawah, U.P.- 206131, in my service records, my mother's name & DOB is wrongly recorded as Resham Devi - 01/01/1955, whereas her correct name & DOB is Reshma Devi - 01/01/1959, vide affidavit dated 04/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1019)C I, Mithlesh W/o- No.15708683M Hav Pavan Kumar, R/o- Vill- Naya Bela, Post- Pachhayyan Gaon, Teh & Dist- Etawah, U.P.- 206131, have changed my name from Mithlesh to Mithlesh Pal, vide affidavit dated 04/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1020)C I, Vishal Singh S/o- Ram Singh, R/o- RZ- 329/1A, Ground Floor, Gali No. 22, Sadh Nagar, Palam Colony, Delhi- 110045, have changed my name from Vishal Singh to Vishal Singh Chauhan. Both names Vishal Singh & Vishal Singh Chauhan pertain to one & same person i.e. myself.

PD(1021)C I, Umra and Umra Sajid D/o Sajid Hussain, A - 54/10- Sanjay Nagar, Gali Number - 14 Mahendra Park, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi 110033, One and the Same Person.

PD(1022)C

Yet to play our best game: Jason Holder

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Jason Holder believes that Gujarat Titans are yet to play their best cricket but have still managed to find a way to win matches and remain in IPL play-off contention.

Holder, who produced a match-winning four-wicket haul against a rampaging Punjab Kings, is happy that every win has been based on collective effort rather than individual brilliance.

"The beauty about how we've been playing is that, it's not one individual performing every single day. There are different players stepping up on different days," Holder said at the post-match press conference after GT beat PBKS by five wickets on Sunday.

"So I think we still arguably haven't played our best game yet but you know, the beauty about that is that we're still getting the two points necessary each time we cross the line." While a target of 164 was chased only with a ball to spare, Holder stressed on getting the two points rather than fretting over the net run-rate. "Look, I think the first priority is always to win the game. If we find ourselves in a position where conditions are favourable that we could think about net run-rate. I think we'll do that.

"But I think the first priority is to accumulate the two points every single time we play and build our momentum. We're on a



So I think we still arguably haven't played our best game yet but you know, the beauty about that is that we're still getting two points necessary each time we cross line — Jason Holder

bit of a roll in terms of three back-to-back wins now. So it's just a matter for us just to stay consistent. I think the run rate and these kind of things will take care of itself." While Holder has got seven wickets in four games, he gave a lot of credit to pacers Kagiso Rabada and

Mohammed Siraj for consistently getting wickets in the Powerplay.

"Credit to both KG and Siraj. I think they've been outstanding this entire competition. You know, they've led the powerplay. I think, in this entire competition. And they've made it difficult for the opposition. You know, that speaks volumes for their class," Holder

was lavish in his praise. In fact, he was quick to point out that not many pace duo in the world would bowl three overs each in Powerplays. "I mean, very rarely have I seen two bowlers, you know, bowling three overs back-to-back in a Powerplay. So it says a lot about their calibre and their quality. I think when they start, you know, they set the tone in terms of what length works on a particular wicket. And then, you know, it's just a matter for all the other bowlers to follow."

Diksha, Tvesa drop down on the final in Mauritius

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Port Louis (Mauritius)

The Indian trio of Diksha Dagar, Tvesa Malik and Hitaashee Bakshi suffered a tough closing round and slipped down the leaderboard at the 2026 MCB Ladies Classic — Mauritius.

After opening with 68-69, Diksha shot a 74 in the third round to finish T-21, while Tvesa, after 70-71, shot 73 and was T-38.

Hitaashee, who carded solid 71-69 on the first two days had a round of 76 and dropped to T-58.

Denmark's Smilla Tarning Soenderby secured her second Ladies European Tour (LET) title becoming the first-ever winner of the 2026 MCB Ladies Classic — Mauritius with a birdie on the last hole.

Diksha had just one birdie on the ninth and dropped shots on the first, 10th and the 15th.

Sweden's Kajsa Arwefall ended the week in a share of second place alongside South Africa's Casandra Alexander one shot behind Soenderby.

Italy's Anna Zanusso set the early clubhouse target firing a sensational bogey-free round of 9-under 63, the best-ever on this golf course and her lowest as a professional, to finish in solo fourth place.

Five players ended the week in a share of fifth place.



Formula 1's electrical revolution losing spark; call for V8 engines



JAMES ELLINGWORTH ■ Miami

Four races into Formula 1's new era and the peak of electrical power's influence on the sport may already be in the rearview mirror.

The Miami Grand Prix was the first under changes which slightly limited the role of the electrical power which has redefined racing this year. The president of the governing body, the FIA, said in Miami he wants traditional V8 engines back in a few years' time.

F1 started the year with some of the biggest changes in its 76-year history, headlined by a 50-50 split in power between a traditional engine and the onboard battery pack. There were only three Grand Prix races under those new rules before a package of tweaks was introduced which curbed the influence of the electrical power. They answered driver criticism by promoting pure driving skill over electrical recharging, especially in qualifying. Discussions on further changes for 2027 could continue that trend.

Sunday's race in Miami was one of the most wide-open in recent F1 history with drivers from four different teams leading before Kimi Antonelli took his third win of 2026 for Mercedes.

V8 engines would take F1 back to the future: When FIA President Mohammed Ben Sulayem first proposed a return to big, noisy traditional engines last year, some F1 figures thought it was an election tactic, and it fizzled out in a meeting with manufacturers. (AP)

Injured Phil Salt returns home for scans

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Royal Challengers Bengaluru opener Phil Salt has returned to England for scans on a finger injury sustained last month.

The injury has kept Salt out of RCB's last three matches, with compatriot Jacob Bethell stepping in at the top of the order. The 29-year-old is reported to



have "damaged a finger on his left hand" while diving to save a boundary at deep backward square leg during RCB's defeat to Delhi Capitals at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium on April 18.

"Salt, who is centrally contracted by the ECB, has since returned home at the request of England's management and has undergone scans on his finger," ESPNcricinfo reported.

Desperate DC seek end to horror run at home



BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Delhi Capitals will need to stop oscillating between sublime and suicidal to overcome their streak of three painful losses at home when they take on an equally desperate Chennai Super Kings in the Indian Premier League here on Tuesday.

Both sides are on eight points from nine games and with five matches remaining, there is no room left for error.

The Capitals put up a clinical batting performance in Jaipur on Friday night to get a welcome win after a hat-trick of defeats. Two of those losses came at home causing immense hurt in the dressing room as Punjab Kings chased down a record 265 before Royal Challengers Bengaluru

exposed their fragile batting against a potent pace attack.

The defeats at Kotla also includes a harrowing one-run loss to Gujarat Titans, a game that DC should have definitely won.

The biggest positives going for DC heading into the CSK game is opener Pathum Nissanka finding his range alongside the ever-consistent KL Rahul while speedster Mitchell Starc providing the much-needed bite to the bowling attack.

No Dhoni yet, Gaikwad's return to form a big boost: Ahead of their 10th game of the season, CSK CEO Kasi Viswanathan confirmed to PTI that MS Dhoni has not yet regained full fitness, ruling him out of the game at Kotla. (PTI)

Rohit, Rickelton power MI to 6-wicket win over LSG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Rohit Sharma (84) made a gratifying return from an injury-enforced layoff and Ryan Rickelton (83) gave another account of his hitting prowess as Mumbai Indians crushed Lucknow Super Giants by six wickets in their Indian Premier League match here on Monday.

Opens Rohit and Rickelton put on their third century partnership in the IPL — this time 143 runs — and laid the foundation for the much-needed win. MI overhauled LSG's 228/5 with 229/4 in 18.4 overs.

The win swelled MI's tally to six from 10 matches and stayed afloat in the IPL but LSG, who have just 4 points from 9 matches to be placed 10th, are now dangerously close to getting knocked out of the race to playoffs.

After Nicholas Pooran made the most of some ordinary bowling from MI with a



21-ball 63, Rohit and Rickelton made merry during their 65-ball stand.

The former Mumbai Indians skipper Rohit had missed five matches due to a hamstring injury which he sustained while batting against Royal Challengers Bengaluru here on April 12.

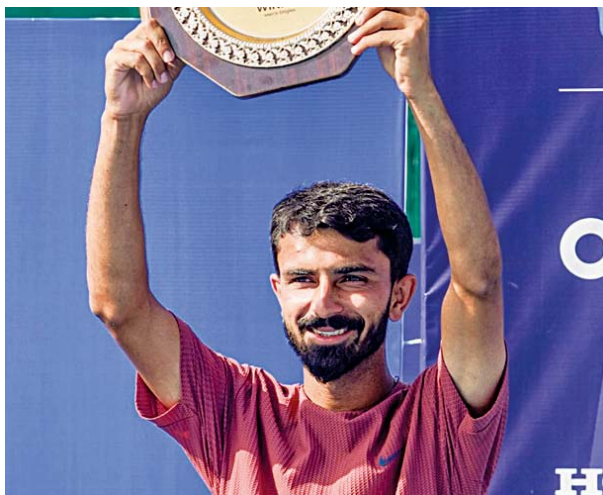
But the 39-year-old showed no discomfort while clubbing seven sixes and six fours during his 44-ball knock,

and Rickelton continued his rich vein of form with commanding stroke play around the park.

But Rickelton fell to Mohsin Khan in the 11th over, playing one straight to cover after a two towering sixes previously.

Rohit looked set for his third IPL ton but he top-edged impact sub Manimaran Siddharth (2/47) to be caught at short fine leg in the 14th over.

Bleeding feet to ending Shoaib's fairytale title win



AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

There were days when Muhammad Shoaib trained in slippers, wearing Salwar Kameez because he couldn't afford shoes and tennis apparel.

There were days when his worn-out shoes had torn soles but he kept on playing, the blisters and oozing blood bearing a testimony of pain he endured for countless hours.

Days when access to a tennis court itself meant waiting for the harsh midday heat, because only then would it be empty enough for someone like him to sneak in a session at Peshawar Club.

On Sunday in Islamabad, that same boy stood as Pakistan's newest tennis

champion and only the third in his country's tennis history after Aisam-ul-Haq Qureshi and Aqeel Khan.

Shoaib's stunning ITF Futures title not only fulfilled a deeply personal dream but also ended a 20-year wait for a Pakistani singles winner, a drought stretching back to 2007, when Aqeel won a Futures event in Lahore and Aisam clinched a Challenger title in Delhi later that year.

Shoaib's title sits at the lowest rung of the Pro Circuit, a humble milestone in a country that has only glimpsed Grand Slam glory through Aisam's doubles exploits. Yet, Pakistan has not tasted much singles success, hence the Shoaib's feat assumes significance in that context.

Jannik Sinner seems unstoppable

ANDREW DAMPF ■ Rome

Most tennis players — even some of the very best ones — have days where they struggle and don't feel the ball the way that they want to.

For top-ranked Jannik Sinner, those types of days are getting rarer and rarer.

And with Carlos Alcaraz sidelined due to a right wrist injury, it doesn't seem like anyone can beat the top-ranked Sinner as the heart of the tennis season approaches with the French Open and Wimbledon coming up over the next two months.

"He's very stable. He doesn't have dips. He doesn't have phases where he goes down," No. 3 Alexander Zverev said after getting routed by Sinner in Sunday's Madrid Open final for his ninth straight loss to the Italian. "That's why he's world number 1."

Sinner's title in the Spanish capital made him the first player to win five consecutive Masters 1000 events — the top tournaments outside of the Grand Slams



— and extended his winning streak to 23 matches.

Sinner hasn't lost since getting beat by Jakob Mensik in the Qatar Open quarterfinals on February 19.

"There's a big gap between Sinner and everybody else right now," Zverev said. "It's quite simple. And to think that at age

24, Sinner is still developing his game.

"He hasn't reached his full potential yet," said Simone Vagnozzi, one of Sinner's coaches. "We're sure of that. And that's key, because when you feel like you've maxed out it's tough to find the motivation to keep training."

Top tennis players slam Roland Garros prize money



SAMUEL PETREQUIN ■ Paris

A group of leading players including Novak Djokovic, Jannik Sinner, Aryna Sabalenka and Coco Gauff have expressed "their deep disappointment" at the level on prize money at Roland Garros amid a lingering dispute with Grand Slam tournament organisers.

The clay-court Grand Slam event starts later this month in western Paris. The players said they have other demands that have not been addressed by officials, including better representation, health and pensions.

The players' call came after French Open organisers announced last



month the Roland Garros prize money has increased by about 10 per cent for an overall pot of 61.7 million euros (\$72.1 million), with the total amount up 5.3 million euros from last year.